

GRANDFATHER'S PIGMENTS

A DA VINCI SUPERNATURAL THRILLER



A Painted Souls Prequel
LEO DI LUX

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GRANDFATHER'S PIGMENTS: A NOVELLA

A PREQUEL TO THE MONA LISA CAGE

THE PAINTED SOULS



LEO DI LUX



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For Nonno, who taught me how to look at a painting until it looked back.

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I. THE UNFINISHED BETRAYER



Antonio da Vinci, margin of the keeper's journal

Leonardo da Vinci
Milan, refectory of Santa Maria delle Grazie
February 1497

THE FACE OPENS ITS EYES BEFORE I FINISH PAINTING THEM.

I freeze mid-stroke. The pupils are not there. I have not rendered them.

Then comes the slow, sick recognition that the wet umber where the eyes should be is moving, not drying, not settling into the plaster the way fresh pigment is supposed to settle, but stirring like oil on water.

Across the half-painted features a smile begins to assemble itself out of nothing I have laid down.

Maestro.

Not a voice. Pressure. Words shoved against the inside of my skull as though from a hand on the other side of bone.

Maestro. I see you.

My palette knife is in my hand before I have chosen to lift it. The blade goes

into the wet pigment, scrapes, gouges, peels back three hours of work in three strokes; burnt umber sprays across the front of my smock and onto the planks of the scaffolding and onto the back of my left wrist. The face goes under the steel. The plaster shows raw beneath, fresh and pale as new bone, scoured clean, and still I can feel her on the other side, pressing with the same patient warmth a child's palm makes against a window glass on a cold morning.

“Maestro?”

Marco. From below, on the floor of the refectory, where the ordinary world still operates. I turn too fast; the scaffolding shifts; my boot finds a knot in the board where my weight should not be.

I crouch. I reach for the rope.

My hand misses.

The palette knife slides out of my fingers, ricochets off the iron clamp on the next board down, falls again. The drop is long. When the blade strikes the stone flagstones of the refectory the sound that comes back up to me is not the sound a knife should make.

The sound is a bell.

It rings once in the high arched ceiling, holds there a moment longer than physics permits, and dies.

Marco stares at the fallen knife, then up at me. His face has gone the colour of the gesso ground I prepared this morning. His chest rises and does not fall.

“The pigments.” My voice arrives from somewhere outside my body. “Incorrectly ground. Fetch fresh vermilion from the workshop.”

He does not move. His eyes drift toward the place on the wall where the face that was not finished had begun to finish itself, then back to me, then to the fallen knife, then to a spot on the floor a few inches from his boot, anywhere, in fact, except where he is being instructed to look.

“Maestro, the wall...”

“Now, Marco.”

The jar of walnut oil he was carrying is on the flagstones at his feet, slowly tipping. He has not noticed. He sets it down at last with the carefulness of a man handling a relic, crosses himself with his thumb in the old Lombard way, hard

and small, the gesture of a man who does not believe in ghosts but has decided this afternoon to hedge, and goes. The heavy door of the refectory closes behind him.

I do not move.

Forty-four years I have carried this body, and lately my knees have begun their old peasant grievance against the weight; but the knees are not the problem this afternoon. The problem is my left hand, which will not stop trembling, which I press flat against my chest to still and which will not be stilled. Below me the palette knife lies where it fell. I cannot make my body climb down to retrieve it.

The refectory is silent.

The kind of silent that has weight. The kind I measured in chapels as a boy, kneeling before the host while the priest raised the bread and the world stopped speaking for the length of his elevation, only without the bread. Without God in it.

The Judas-shaped wound in my wall waits.

WHEN AT LAST I CLIMB DOWN, THE DESCENT TAKES LONGER THAN IT SHOULD. I have done this every day for two years and my body knows every rung, every soft place where the boards creak; today my body has forgotten its own work, and I count the rungs as if they are a stranger's stairs.

At the bottom the palette knife lies where Marco's eyes left it. I do not pick it up. I cross to the long view, the place where the great Dominican brothers enter in procession on feast days, where a viewer first sees the *Cenacolo* whole, and from there the wall finally permits me the geometry of what I have made.

Eleven faces look back at me.

Christ at the centre. His left hand turned up, open: *one of you will betray me*. His right hand turned down, closed: *and the betrayer's bread is in this dish*. The whole composition lives in those two hands, and I painted them across November and most of December knowing that anything anyone says about this wall for a thousand years will begin with the way the left hand opens.

To Christ's right, Peter lunges with the knife, the one I studied in the meat district along the Naviglio, where I spent three afternoons sketching the wrists of a butcher named Giacomo whose tendons knotted into the specific muscle that pulls a blade across a throat. Peter's hand on this wall is Giacomo's hand. Peter does not know it.

Beyond Peter, John has swooned. James the Greater throws his hands up. Thomas raises his single finger toward heaven, his question already forming.

Then the empty space.

The blank shape where Judas Iscariot ought to clutch his thirty silver. A wound in the composition: roughly ten inches by twelve, the dimensions of a face and therefore the dimensions of an absence, the plaster paler than the surrounding wall because it has been scraped seventeen times.

The other apostles ring the table and look at one another, look at Christ, look at the bread and the wine and the slowly forming knife. Their gazes complete a circuit, a closed circle that holds the viewer's eye inside the painting. Judas would break the circle. Judas is supposed to break the circle.

I move closer than I have come today, close enough that my breath should mist on the cold plaster, would mist if I were breathing.

I am not breathing.

I do not touch the wall. I do not need to.

The plaster is not thick enough to hide this.

I know its thickness. I supervised its construction. Three-quarters of an inch of plaster, then brick, then mortar, then the cloister of the Dominicans, where six monks are at this moment chanting Vespers and have not yet noticed that the wall between us has begun to grow soft.

Seventeen attempts.

The thought goes nowhere. I let it sit.

I HAVE FAILED AT FINISHING THINGS BEFORE. THE ADORATION SITS IN FLORENCE, unfinished, a brown ghost of underdrawing waiting for colour I will never lay down. The great bronze horse stands as clay in Ludovico's courtyard waiting for

a casting that the city's gunmakers want the bronze for instead. The mechanical lion I designed for the French. The diving apparatus. The flying machine. I am a man who begins.

The seventeen Judases are not that kind of unfinished. The seventeen Judases were finished. Each of them. And then unmade.

The first was too cruel. I gave him the face of a moneylender I had known in Florence, all jaw and appetite, and as the pigment began to dry the eyes shifted under my brush. The cruelty became something I could not paint with. Something that looked back. I scraped it that same afternoon, before the prior arrived to inquire after my progress.

The second was too pious. I tried to imagine Judas as he had been before the betrayal, the boy from Kerioth who had followed a teacher. The face I painted was tender. The pigment had not dried when the tenderness inverted, and the mouth I had given that boy became a mouth I no longer wanted in my refectory after dark.

The third was too young. The fourth too old. The fifth had eyes I could not bear to keep on the wall after sunset.

The sixth was the one I noticed.

The sixth was correct. I rendered the underdrawing in red ochre, laid in the flesh tones with the same technique I had used on Bartholomew, the same pigments, the same brushes, the same hand. The composition demanded a man who had decided. The man I painted had decided. He was ordinary, neither cruel nor tender, neither young nor old, with the calm of a small functionary at his master's table.

Then the pigment began to dry, and something else rushed to fill the form.

Not my Judas. Another face. Pressing through the plaster from behind the wet pigment, opening within the shape I had outlined, smiling with a mouth that was not the mouth I had given. I scraped him before the smile finished.

Seventeen, now.

Dimmi: how can a face see without eyes?

The question that came to me on the scaffolding this afternoon arrives again, weighted differently at the long view. From here the seventeen attempts

compress into a single absence, a door left open in the geometry of my Christ.

Behind me the pigments wait on the shelf where I left them at dawn: malachite for green, lead-tin yellow, *azzurro della Magna* I bought from a Genoese merchant for more than the monks' yearly bread, vermilion freshly ground this morning by Marco's still-thin fingers. The dust motes drift through the slanted afternoon light. The light is doing what light has always done.

Maestro.

Faint. Not in my head this time. In the wall.

You are painting toward the wrong face. He is not in the gospels. He is in the geometry of your own composition.

I do not turn. I do not answer.

Artists return to their masterpieces.

The phrase rises in me without invitation, summoned from somewhere outside my own thinking. I have heard it said, among the masters in Florence, in the bottega gossip, in the way one painter speaks of another at a long dinner he was not invited to. I have not, until this winter, understood it as a sentence of imprisonment.

The voice in the wall waits for me.

I APPROACH THE WALL.

The afternoon light is leaving. In another hour the refectory will be the colour of unmilled flour, and in another two the colour of the inside of a tomb. I will need lamps if I am to work. I do not intend to work. I do not, in fact, intend to remain in this room. But my feet have brought me to the wall as feet have brought men to confession boxes for fifteen hundred years, and I am, in this small surrendering moment, no different from a man on his knees.

I lift my hand to the plaster.

An inch from the surface, I stop.

The plaster is cold. The refectory is cold. Lombardy in February is the wet cold that settles into the joints of an old building and stays there until April. The plaster is colder than the air around it, which is what plaster should be, but only

just.

I press my palm flat against the Judas-space.

Something presses back.

Not heat. Not exactly heat. Pressure: the smallest pressure, an ounce, perhaps less, but present and willed, the pressure a child's hand makes against a window, the pressure a hand makes against a hand.

You are too kind to him.

Her voice in the wall. No syllables. The shape of words laid against the inside of my skull as if from a hand on the other side of bone.

Your apostles look at one another. They look at Christ. They look at the bread. Their gazes complete a circuit. Your Judas is alone, you have decided who he is before giving him a face. You have left him faceless because you are afraid he will look ordinary.

My palm rests on the plaster. The plaster's pressure rests on my palm. We are touching.

I have known many men who would betray Christ for thirty silver, she goes on, conversational, the way a fellow craftsman might lean against the bench in the corner of a workshop, and I have collected them. I can give you a face, Maestro. A face the world will recognise.

My hand does not move.

Your bronze horse, Maestro. Fourteen years of bozzetti. The clay is still in Ludovico's courtyard. Shall I tell you where it will be melted, and by whom, and in what year? Shall I tell you what becomes of the wax models you have shown only to your apprentices? I have read your notebooks, not the ones you keep open on the table, the other ones, the ones you write left-handed in the mirror.

The pressure on my palm steadies, as if she has settled into a more comfortable posture against the inside of the wall, the way a guest settles into a chair offered by a host who has not yet realised the visit will be long.

Set his gaze outward, she says, returning to the business of her commission. Let him meet the viewer's eyes. Let the betrayal be seen, not hidden among gestures. The composition demands it.

She is correct.

This is the worst thing she has said.

She is correct, and I have known it for weeks, perhaps months, perhaps since the eleventh attempt, the composition demands a face that breaks the circle. It demands a Judas who looks out at the room, who looks at the monks at their meal, who looks at the wealthy donors when they come on feast days to admire what their florins have purchased. The painting requires it. The geometry requires it. I have been pretending otherwise, but I have spent my life understanding geometry, and geometry does not lie.

She has just told me how to finish my masterpiece, and I have just understood that the moment I do, the door opens.

Yes, she says, as if my thought were spoken aloud. *Yes. Now we understand each other.*

My palm has begun to sweat against the cold plaster. I can feel her fingers on the other side of the wall. They have a shape now. They mirror mine. Five against five. The pressure increases.

“I will not finish his face today.”

I have spoken aloud. My voice is level. How my voice is level, I do not know.

The pressure does not lessen. The pressure becomes thoughtful.

I have time, Maestro.

Her voice has changed. The argument is over. The critic has heard the gallery’s verdict and is unconcerned.

The plaster will dry. And dry plaster, in the end, will take whatever face we agree upon.

I pull my hand away. The pressure releases. The plaster is plaster again, cold and February and three-quarters of an inch thick, with a cloister behind it and six men in it chanting the Office of the dead.

I look down at my hand.

The burnt umber from the scraped face is still on my skin, the smear by the thumb. I scraped it three hours ago. By now the pigment should be cool, tacky, beginning to flake. By now the pigment should not behave.

The pigment is warm.

THE DOOR OPENS. I AM STILL AT THE WALL WHEN MARCO RETURNS, MY HAND still raised in front of me, my palm still warm with what was on the other side of the plaster. He hesitates at the threshold. He is not alone.

“Maestro,” he says. “The Prior.”

Vincenzo Bandello. Prior of Santa Maria delle Grazie, friend of dukes, second cousin to a cardinal, and, for the past two years, the man whose patience I have measured in audiences instead of florins. He is a small, round, methodical Lombard with a face that arranges itself for any conversation by first deciding what kind of conversation it would prefer not to be having. Just now his face has decided that this conversation will be reluctant.

He steps into the refectory. He looks at the scaffolding. He looks at the palette knife on the flagstones, where it has been lying since Marco crossed himself over it half an hour ago. He looks at the Judas-shaped wound on the wall. He does not look at it for long.

“Maestro Leonardo.”

“Prior.”

“The Duke,” he says, in the tone of a man who has been instructed to deliver a message and would prefer the message had been entrusted to a courier, “has asked again.”

“The Duke asks weekly. The Duke is to be commended for his persistence.”

“Maestro.”

“Prior.”

“He has asked,” Bandello says, with a small and careful precision, “whether you would be insulted if he engaged a second hand. A Florentine, from Verrocchio’s old workshop. Lorenzo di Credi, I think, would be the...”

“He would not be insulted on my behalf, Prior. He would be insulting me directly. There is a difference.”

“He understands the difference.”

“And yet he proposes it.”

Bandello’s face acquires the thin smile of a man who has spent a long career

mediating disputes between sons-in-law and the saints. “He proposes it, Maestro, because for fourteen months you have given him a wall that is eleven-twelfths of a Last Supper. Mathematically he is correct that we are eleven-twelfths nearer the feast than we were when you began. Theologically he is correct that the eleven-twelfth is not the part that matters.”

The Judas-shape behind him does not move. I am very aware that it does not move. I am very aware that I must remain aware that it does not move.

“Prior. There is no second hand. Not on this wall. Not on this face.”

“Maestro.”

“Not on this face.”

“Forgive me, Maestro. May I ask why the face refuses you?”

He has asked this in four previous audiences. The question has cost him something to keep asking. In each audience I have given a different lie. *The composition demands further study. The pigment requires longer drying. The Duke’s choice of subject obliges an unusual treatment.* I am running out of lies. I have known for some weeks now that I am running out of lies, and that the Prior knows I know, and that the next audience after this one will not be a polite one.

“The face,” I say, “is a difficult problem.”

“All faces are difficult problems.”

“Not all faces are betrayals.”

He waits for me to continue. I do not. He looks once at the Judas-shape and once at the palette knife, and then, perhaps for the second time in our acquaintance, at me, as if measuring something he is not in the habit of measuring.

“Maestro. If you require additional study, study. The Duke will allow another month. He will not allow another six. You know this. I have told him you know this.” He pauses. “I have also told him I have eaten my breakfast in this refectory for fourteen years, and that in fourteen years I have never once felt cold in this room until this winter. He laughed. I did not.”

He turns to leave. At the door he stops.

“Maestro. The face Christ looks toward. It is not the face you have left blank.”

“Prior?”

He does not answer the question. He goes. Marco follows him out with the apologetic step of an apprentice between two larger weathers, and the door closes behind them.

It is some seconds before I can move again.

When I do, it is to a small wooden chest in the corner where I keep correspondence I will not throw away, and that is where Marco finds me when he comes back a quarter of an hour later, with the courier behind him.

The wax is black.

I take the letter. Marco lingers. The courier turns to go.

“Marco. Go home.”

“Maestro...”

“Go home.”

The handwriting on the address belongs to my father, Ser Piero da Vinci, notary of Florence, who has not written to me in nearly six years and writes now in the small deliberate hand of a man who charges by the legal phrase. I break the seal. I read the letter once. I read it again. I do not feel the news, because the news is more than thirty years old and has only now decided to arrive.

The box has changed.

The thought has the flatness of an entry in a notary’s ledger, which is the only register my father owns. *The chest your grandfather left in my keeping, that I was charged to hold shut and to speak of to no one until it should alter, has altered. There is frost on the wax in a warm room. It carries a weight it did not carry. My father’s instruction was plain, and I have kept it more than thirty years against my own wishes: when the box wakes, it goes to Leonardo, and to no one else, and not in Vinci. Come and take this thing out of my house.* I would have written it in his voice had he not. He is a man who writes the waking of buried things the way the rest of us write inventories.

I fold the letter. I am to come to Vinci.

I cannot leave Milan now, not with the Judas unfinished and her hand pressing through the wall and the plaster warm where it should be cold. I have a thousand reasons that are not the reason. The reason is that I have spent thirty

years not thinking about my grandfather's box, and the wall has spent three weeks teaching me that I was wrong to stop.

I unlock the chest where I keep what is left of him. Inside, near the top, are seven letters in his hand, the ink gone brown, the paper soft with handling and age. He wrote them to a boy. The last is more than thirty years old. In every one of them, somewhere, he told me he was tired, and that he had something to send when the time was right, and I was a child and did not think to ask what, and then he was in the ground and the time was never right, and I came north and became Leonardo and let the letters go brown in a chest.

I lift the seven letters.

The fourth, from beneath, is not where I left it. It sits closer to the top than I left it, and I have not opened this chest in years.

Someone has moved the letter. I did not move the letter.

I close the chest. I sit on the bench beside it. The shaking has spread to both hands.

Behind me, in the Judas-shaped wound in the wall, the plaster is no longer drying.

THE LIGHT LEAVES US SLOWLY. I DO NOT LIGHT THE LAMPS. THE REFECTORY deepens from afternoon into the colour of unmilled flour, then linen, then the inside of a tomb, and I should go: the monks will come for Vespers in the connecting cloister, and they will hear me alone here in the dark, and the rumours about the Florentine who scrapes his own work each afternoon will become rumours about the Florentine who haunts his own work after dusk.

Rumour I can survive. I do not move.

When I finally rise, my legs have forgotten how to be legs. I cross to the wall by the memory of crossings. The Judas-space is the dimension of a man's face: ten inches by twelve, perhaps her face, though I do not know if she has a face, do not know if a face is what she is asking me to give her.

I lift my hand to within an inch of the plaster.

The plaster bulges.

So small a movement that for a moment I do not trust my eyes. I have not slept properly in three weeks; I have stopped eating with regularity; I am a man whose eyes have invented many things, the way all painters' eyes invent things, the way we are paid to invent them. But I have watched plaster dry every day of my working life, and wet plaster does not bulge.

The bulge holds: a swelling no larger than the back of a knuckle, pushed outward toward my waiting palm.

I lay my palm against it. For two heartbeats, the bulge is fingers, five of them, splayed against the inside of the wall, the pads of them pressing through the plaster the way a child presses through a stretched bedsheet. Thumb. Index. Middle. Ring. The little finger curled slightly inward.

I have dissected hands. I know what a hand feels like through a thin barrier. I know the difference between the texture of skin and the texture of plaster. I do not invent this.

I pull my hand away. The bulge subsides.

The fingers were not fingers, I tell myself, and the lie is so transparent that even she does not bother with it.

Maestro.

Soft. Almost gentle. The voice that came up to me on the scaffolding hours ago.

Did you feel my hand?

I do not answer.

The door is in the wall.

The thought arrives in the chamber of my own skull, and I cannot say whether I have thought it or whether she has placed it there. The distinction has stopped meaning what it should.

I turn to leave. I get three steps. My hand is on the iron handle of the refectory door, and I am going to walk out of this room and not return tonight, possibly never return alone after dark, possibly never return at all.

I look back.

In the Judas-space, where there should be only scraped plaster in the failing light, there is a smile, wide, pleasant, patient enough to require no patience. The

smile of a guest at a dinner arranged for the guest's benefit. It is there for the half-second I look at it, and then it is plaster again. Plaster, wet plaster, nothing. The light is failing. My eyes are tired. I have not slept. The smile was not a smile. The fingers were not fingers.

I open the door. I step into the cloister. I close the door behind me and turn the key, and the iron clicks into place with the sound of a thing being made certain.

I stand outside the door for a long time. The monks pass on their way to choir. They nod. The Prior is among them now, he has not changed his coat since the afternoon, and he looks at me a moment longer than the others. He does not stop. He has a long memory for slights and a longer memory for unpaid commissions, and the next audience between us will not be polite.

When the cloister is empty, I speak aloud. The vault catches my voice and holds it as the refectory caught the bell of the fallen palette knife.

"I will go to Vinci."

II. THE LITTLE DEVIL



“Every keeper inherits two things. The pigments. And the proof that someone before him failed.”

Antonio da Vinci, keeper’s journal, undated page

Leonardo da Vinci

Leonardo’s workshop, Corte Vecchia, Milan

Late February 1497

THE ROAD TO VINCI TOOK FOUR DAYS, THE ROAD BACK ANOTHER FOUR, AND I have been in Milan two more. The cart that brought the box is in the stable behind the Corte Vecchia, the driver paid, the donkey unhitched and led to feed. The box itself sits on the workbench in the upper room of my workshop, where I placed it perhaps fifteen minutes ago, and where I have not stopped looking at it since.

The workshop is cold. Eighteen months ago this room would have held seven apprentices and two journeymen: the noise of bronze molds being inverted for the great horse, the smell of fresh-grated charcoal, the constant low argument over who had borrowed whose chisel. Today there is one brazier burning low

and one lamp lit beyond what the high window provides. The bronze horse molds have gone into the cellar where Ludovico's men carted them after the Duke decided the bronze was wanted for cannon-stock. The apprentices have been reassigned to the Castello, where Ludovico is building rooms for guests who will never come because the French are coming first.

I have lit the brazier myself, and laid the bread Marco left for me on a stool I am not sitting on. The shop smells of dust on cold linseed, of the inside of a cabinet that has not been opened in a season.

The box smells of nothing.

I am aware of that. A box that has held seven sealed vials of pigment, plus a journal, plus a wrapped panel, plus whatever else my grandfather left for me, should smell of *something*: wood, wax, the slow incense of old paper. This box smells of nothing.

There was no one to bury. My grandfather has lain in the churchyard at Vinci more than thirty years, in the plot beside my grandmother and the empty stones for the children who did not live to be named. I stood at the grave a while in the February rain. The stone has the soft edges stone gets in thirty years of weather. I was twelve the last time I stood on that ground, the autumn the leaves came down the colour of old coins, and I held the cord they lowered him by, and I did not understand then that the family was not only burying a man but closing a door they were all relieved to be shut of.

My father kept the box closed the whole while I was in Vinci, the way he has kept it closed for thirty years. He gave it to me only when I was leaving, on the road outside town, where he could be sure no one in the family would see it change hands.

"It goes to you," he said. "Only to you. Not in Vinci. He was very clear, at the end, and I have kept his clarity longer than I have kept anything of my own. Take it out of my house, Leonardo, and do not write to me of it again."

He had stood there in his good wool, the rain at his collar, his face arranged for a conversation he had rehearsed for thirty years and prayed he would never have to give. I waited for him to say more. He did not. I have not asked my father what he knew. He has not offered.

I sit on a stool. The bread is hard, cold to the touch. I do not eat it. I have not opened the box.

For fifteen minutes my hand has not crossed the small distance between my lap and the lid. There is a brass hook on the lid that needs to be lifted to release the latch. The hook is perhaps the length of my smallest finger. I cannot make my hand close on it.

“YOU ARE BACK.”

The voice from the room below. Salai. Up the stairs in eleven quick strides, the way only Salai climbs stairs, every step half a stride longer than it should be. He arrives in the doorway with a small loaf of dark bread tucked under one arm, a wedge of pecorino in waxed paper, a bowl of olives glistening from their oil, and half a flask of wine he probably did not pay for.

Seventeen years old. Curls he refuses to cut. The boy who climbed those stairs at ten and never quite left.

He takes in the room in two passes. The first pass: the cold brazier, the unlit lamps, the stool with the untouched bread on it, my hands in my lap. The second pass: the box.

He does not ask about the box.

He sets the food on the bench beside it. He cuts the loaf with the knife I have not seen him return to the kitchen, ever, in seven years. He pushes a piece across the wood without looking up.

“Eat.”

“I am not hungry.”

“So either you are lying about not being hungry, or you are lying about working. Either way you owe me an answer when you finish chewing.”

I take the bread.

He cuts the pecorino with the same knife and arranges the olives in a careful line along the rim of the bowl, smallest to largest, as if presentation might persuade me. He pours wine into the single cup we keep on this bench, drinks half of it, and pushes the rest to me.

“You were gone ten days.”

“Four there. Two at Vinci. Four back.”

“You never told me your grandfather had left you anything.”

“I did not know he had, until my father wrote that it had started to wake.”

Salai considers this, choosing not to ask the question he is choosing not to ask. He has been told, twice in his life, things about the da Vinci dead that he did not ask to be told. The first time he asked questions. The second time he did not. He has learned that the da Vinci dead are not the kind one asks about, and that my grandfather, thirty years buried, is somehow the least dead of all of them.

The bread is good. I had not known I was this hungry. I had not known anything about my body since the scaffolding. I eat half the slice before I notice I am eating, and Salai is watching me, and Salai’s mouth has done the small private movement that means he has registered my hands trembling.

He says nothing about the trembling.

“You went without me.”

“I did.”

“You could have taken me. It is not a complicated journey.”

“You hate Vinci. The last time I took you, you spent three days asking me when the Florentines were going to learn how to make a proper sausage.”

“It is a fair question. The Florentines hide too much fennel in everything. The fennel does not help.”

“You ate four of them anyway.”

“I was a guest. A guest does not refuse fennel sausage on principle.” He sips from the cup, which is now his cup. “Did Ser Piero ask after me.”

“No.”

“He did not even ask if I was still alive.”

“He would not assume so.”

“That hurts.” He selects an olive, holds it between thumb and forefinger, inspects it for whatever olives are inspected for. “Maestro. Marco came by yesterday.”

I look up.

“He came by the workshop?”

“Twice. The second time he had been drinking. He said the refectory has gone cold, and he is not going back.”

“He is supposed to be back tomorrow.”

“Marco is not going back, Maestro. Marco has, in his own words, decided to be a bricklayer.”

“He is fourteen.”

“He is fourteen and frightened. He says you have started painting Christ in a refectory that is no longer warm, and that the brushes do not behave for you, and that something in the wall watches him from the place where you are not painting the Judas.” Salai pulls another olive from the bowl, examines it, sets it back unchewed. “He used the word *watches*, Maestro. Three times.”

I do not answer.

“So.” Salai’s eyes settle on the box. “Either Marco has invented a story, which would be the only invention of his career, or you have not been telling me something. Open the box.”

I OPEN THE BOX.

I open it because Salai is watching me, and I have spent twenty-three years in this city building a reputation for not being a man who can be watched into doing things he does not wish to do, and watched is exactly what he is doing. The brass hook lifts. The latch releases. The lid rises on a small hinge I do not remember my grandfather buying.

The smell that comes out of the box is faint, mineral, with a thin thread of something I will think about later and not be able to name. Not incense. Not myrrh. Older than either.

Top layer: a small leather-bound journal, oil-stained at the corners. A loose page folded on top, addressed in my grandfather’s hand.

Middle layer: seven small clay pots, each no larger than a hazelnut shell. Each sealed with red wax, each stamped with a different mark scratched into the seal by a knife-point. Blue ink. Red ink. Gold leaf pressed into the wax. White. Black. Green. And one unmarked.

Bottom layer: a wrapped panel. Linen, tied with cord, the cord knotted in a particular way.

I lift the blue pot first. Hold it up to the brazier. The flame in the brazier should reflect off the wax seal as orange, the way flame reflects off any wax in any room. The flame does not reflect off this wax. The brazier's light goes into the pot and does not come back. A small dark spot now sits between my hand and the brazier, and the corner of the room behind it has become slightly easier to see.

"That is wrong," Salai says, with the certainty of a man stating that gravity is operating today as expected.

"Yes."

I set the blue pot down.

The red is second. The weight is wrong. The pot is the size of a hazelnut shell, should weigh perhaps three drachms; instead it weighs in my hand as if it weighed half a pound. Not from mass. From pull. The pot wants to be set down on the earth, and my fingers tire holding it up against the pull.

I set the red pot down.

The gold pot is cold. Not cool. Cold. Cold enough that when Salai reaches across and touches it with the back of his knuckle, condensation forms in the spaces between his fingers and the wax in three small beads.

"Maestro." He says it very quietly. "That pot is cold."

"I know."

"What is in it?"

"I do not know yet."

He pulls his hand back from the gold, examines the knuckle, finds nothing wrong with it. He waits for me to lift another pot. I look at the white pot, the black, the green, the unmarked one. I have the sense, from looking at them in the wood of the box, that I do not want to lift them. My grandfather laid them in this order on purpose. The three I have lifted are the three he wanted me to lift first. The four I have not lifted are the four he wanted me not to lift at all.

I close the lid on the middle layer. I lift the loose page from the top of the journal. I read.

I DO NOT READ THE PAGE ALOUD. NOT YET. I READ IT ONCE, TO MYSELF, AND fold it and place it on the bench beside the journal. Salai watches me fold it. He does not ask what it says. He has learned the particular silence that means I will not be asked.

“There is one more thing in the box.”

“I saw.”

I reach into the bottom layer and lift the wrapped panel.

The panel is the size of a man’s face. Approximately ten inches by twelve. The dimensions are exact. I have measured the Judas-space with my eye every day for the last seven months, and I know its proportions. The panel in my hands is the Judas-space.

Coincidences of this kind are not coincidences.

The cord is tied in a knot I last saw my grandfather tie when I was six years old. He taught me to tie it once, in the kitchen of his small farmhouse: the country knot used by men who tie game to a pole and carry it home from the hill. He tied it that day around a rabbit he had killed and given to me for my saint’s day. I remember the cord’s bite into the rabbit’s fur. I remember thinking the knot was kind, because it did not slip even when the rabbit was carried by a child too small to be careful.

I untie the knot.

The dust pattern on the cord is intact until my fingers touch it. No one has handled this cord since my grandfather laid it in the box. For a moment I have the unhelpful sensation of his hands on the cord beneath mine; I let it pass.

The linen falls away. I turn the panel over.

Four old lines of dulled gold frame the face, cracked at the corners. The gold has the patina of decades. Antonio laid it in his thirty-third year, and it has been holding what it was laid to hold ever since, until now.

The face is wrong.

Not crudely wrong. Not amateurishly wrong. The features have been placed correctly by every drawing-master’s rule: the eyes sit in the right plane, the nose

has the correct length, the mouth is the right width below the nose. The technique of the underpainting is my grandfather's, and I recognise the order of his shadow tones, the way he prepares a flesh ground with a green-brown beneath that gives the skin its life.

But the features have been assembled wrong. Not against the rules. *Through* the rules. The eyes sit slightly too low for the way I have seen Antonio draw a face; the mouth has been pulled, not into an expression, but into the negative space that lives between expressions; the brows are correct, but they have been laid above a forehead that has been drawn the way the wax of a candle has been drawn, halfway to softening. The face is what I would see if I stopped a man's face halfway through a yawn and froze it where it lost meaning.

This is what the seventeen Judases would have looked like, if any of them had dried.

Salai goes still.

Salai is rarely still. The stillness of Salai is the stillness of a cat that has heard the door of a cage close. He does not approach the panel. He does not come closer than the bench will permit him.

"Whose face was that," he says.

"Hers. Or what her face becomes when a keeper has set her in a prison and the prison has begun to crack."

"It looks wrong."

"It is correct. That is what an imprisoned face looks like. Antonio painted it in his thirty-third year. It held for thirty years. It is failing now."

"Why is it failing?"

"Because she has found another door. The wall in my refectory."

Salai is quiet. He looks at the panel again. He sees what I see: the face is not a man's face, and it never was, although for two days I had let myself think so. The face is hers, half-rendered, half-undone, the door-state of a thing that should have been held closed.

"Turn that one to the wall, Maestro. Now."

I turn the panel to the wall. I rest it against the leg of the workbench. The half-painted face is now staring at the wood; I cannot see it, the bench can.

“Better,” Salai says. He sits down. His hands lie flat on the bench. He does not pick up an olive. “Read me the letter.”

I READ ALOUD NOW.

I read aloud because the only way I can stand to read this slowly enough to understand it is to make my mouth do the work my eyes are no longer trustworthy for. Salai sits across the bench, arms folded against his chest the way men stand at funerals when they have decided the priest is taking too long.

My grandfather’s hand is small and meticulous in the early entries; it loosens as the journal goes on. The pages I read from are toward the end.

“There are seven pigments. Three are safe to use. Blue, red, gold. The other four are emergency colours. Do not break their seals unless the alternative is your death or the death of the world.”

Salai’s olive pit clicks against the rim of the bowl.

“The pigments are made from minerals taken from places where she has touched the earth. Each colour retains a fraction of her property. The blue holds depth. The red holds life. The gold holds voice.”

I turn the page.

“I have called her La Famelica, because hunger is the only name she has ever answered to. She has older names. I will not write them. To write them is to invite a visit.”

“Famelica,” Salai says, tasting the word. “The hungry one.”

“Yes.”

“It fits.”

“What is the white,” Salai’s voice. “And the black. And the green.”

“He does not say.”

“He does not say because they should not be said?”

“He does not say because he was tired.”

I keep reading.

“The portrait in the box is the prison I made for her in my thirty-third year. It held for thirty years. I think it is now cracking. I do not know how long it will

hold. I do not know whether the wall at Santa Maria delle Grazie is the same prison opening from a different side, or whether she has opened a second door. If you are reading this and the wall is bleeding her through, then it is the same prison, and the second door must be sealed at the same moment as the first."

I stop. Salai is looking at the wrapped panel against the leg of the workbench. I keep reading.

"The pigments take their price from the painter's life-record. Memory. Sight. The body's quiet usefulnesses. The things you do not know you have until you no longer have them. I have spoken twice in my life with pigments, and I have paid each time. I will not tell you what I paid. You will know when you reach for it and it is no longer there."

The room is quiet. Salai has not moved.

The last entry is dated less than a month ago. The handwriting has lost most of its precision; it is the hand of a man writing through stiff fingers.

"Leonardo, my grandson. I had hoped to die before this letter became necessary. I did not. The work is yours now. I am sorry."

I close the journal.

The brazier has burned lower. Salai's olive is gone. The bowl is empty; but he has not eaten the others, he has lined them up by size and left them.

"He knew you would inherit it," Salai says.

"Yes."

"Did he know I would be here."

I do not answer. My hand crosses the bench and finds his wrist. I do not look at him; he does not look at me. I hold his wrist for the length of two breaths. I take my hand back. He keeps his where it was, palm against the wood.

"Maestro."

"Yes."

"That last entry. The hand of a man writing through stiff fingers." He picks an olive from the line he has arranged, the second one, the second smallest. "He was your grandfather. He was eighty-two years old when he wrote that. He was sorry."

"He was."

“Then I am sorry for him also.” He pulls the pit out, sets it on the rim. “Read me the rest. The part you skipped.”

I look at him.

“Maestro. You skipped a page. You always skip the page that matters.”

I read the page I had skipped.

The page contains seven names. Seven cities. Seven dates. None of the dates is in this century. The latest is 1304. The names are keepers. The dates are when each keeper died. *Failed*, the journal says, in Antonio’s hand, beside each name.

The seven failures are men who tried, before my grandfather, to do what my grandfather did at thirty-three: paint her in. Each of them, like the panel now turned to the wall against the workbench leg, failed.

The seventh name is the name of a Florentine. The seventh date is 1304.

Salai counts on his fingers as I read. He uses both hands. He arrives at the answer.

“Eight,” he says. “There are at least eight of you. There were.”

“There were.”

“And now.”

“Now there is one.”

“TELL ME ABOUT THE WALL.”

I tell him. I do not tell him cleanly; the wall is not the kind of thing one tells cleanly. I tell him about Marco. I tell him about the seventeen attempts. I tell him about the bell of the falling palette knife. I tell him about her voice in the plaster, her hand on the other side of the plaster, the bulge that was fingers, the smile that was not a smile. I tell him I went to Vinci because I did not know what else to do. I tell him I have come back with my grandfather’s box and a wrapped panel I do not know how to use.

I tell him all of this in perhaps four minutes.

Salai listens. He has retrieved the olives. He picks another from the bowl, slowly, with the particular care a man takes when his hands wish to busy themselves. The pit goes on the rim of the bowl in the place its size would

warrant.

“The panel,” he says, “is the same shape as the wall.”

“Yes.”

“Your grandfather made the panel to hold her.”

“I believe so.”

“And she is now in the wall, too.”

“Yes.”

He pulls another olive. He works the pit clean with his teeth in the small private motion he has done since he was ten, and sets the pit beside the first.

“Then either she is in two places, Maestro. Or the two places are the same place. With two doors.”

I stop moving.

Salai notices. He does not look at me. He pulls the third olive.

“If the door is in the wall,” he says, around the olive, “then she has hands on both sides. Close one side, you have closed nothing. She just comes through the other.”

He swallows. He sets the third pit on the rim. The three pits sit in a careful descending row. He has still not looked at me.

He is right.

I do not say it. The thought sits in the room between us. He does not need me to say it; I can see in the line of his shoulders that he knows what he has just said, and that he is pretending not to know, because if he has known it then I have known it, and if I have known it then I have known what we will have to do.

“Salai.”

“Maestro.”

“The panel in your hand.”

He looks down at his hand. There is no panel in it. There is an olive, the fourth one. He has been holding it for some time.

“I have an olive, Maestro. I had three. The first one was very good. The second was acceptable. The third tasted of brine that has been brine for too long, but I ate it out of solidarity with the first two.”

“Salai. Be serious.”

“I am being serious, Maestro. I have just told you the price of an olive. Now you will tell me the price of the other thing.”

“I do not know yet.”

“You do not know yet, or you have been afraid to open it.”

I look at him. He looks at me. The lamp on the bench gutters; the lamp catches his eye and his eye catches the lamp; and for a moment the boy I am looking at is not seventeen, is not the boy who climbed the stairs at ten and refused to leave. He is a man of perhaps thirty, perhaps forty, with my grandfather's face. Antonio is looking at me through the lamp, the way Antonio looked at me when I was nine and had been caught.

It is a trick of the lamp. The lamp steadies. The boy is seventeen again.

“Salai. You should not be here.”

“Maestro. Where else would I be.”

WE PREPARE THE WORKSHOP FOR SLEEP.

The work is small and practiced. Salai banks the brazier. I set out the two pallets. Salai takes the one nearer the door, the warmer one, because he sleeps cold and I sleep through anything. The pallets are thin. The straw smells of camphor I put in last summer to keep mice out, the camphor has gone faint, and a mouse has investigated. There is a small bitten place at the corner of Salai's pallet. He notices, and moves the pallet half a foot toward the bench, away from the bitten corner, with the particular concentration he applies to things he wants no one to know he cares about.

He lies down. He is asleep within a minute.

Salai sleeps the way cats sleep: completely, unguarded, his mouth open just enough to show the chip on his upper left tooth he got from biting a melon stone at six, his curls fallen across his forehead. The breath that comes out of him is slow and unconcerned, and I want to draw him, and I cannot draw him because I have set out the candle but I have not the wit to lift a pen.

I lie on my own pallet. I watch the room.

The brazier light is dying. The lamp Salai lit when he came in is the last working light. As the brazier ebbs, the shadows on the wall above the wrapped panel begin to gather. Not a face. Not yet. The outline of where a face might assemble itself.

I do not get up. I do not move. I watch the shadow.

The shadow does not become a face. It remains an outline: the forehead's edge against the wall, the hollow of the cheekbone, the jaw line, unsettled. A shape that is almost a face. A shape waiting.

The outline is not a face, I think. The outline is what a face would be, if it had time.

The brazier dies entirely. The shadow goes with it. The lamp Salai lit gutters in the last of its oil and goes out without ceremony.

The room is dark. Salai's breath continues.

In Vinci, when I was nine, my grandfather Antonio put me to bed in the small upstairs room of his farmhouse and stood at the door watching the lamp. He stood there for an hour. I asked him eventually what he was watching. He said: *the light, Leonardo, only the light. Sleep.* I slept. I dreamed of nothing. In the morning he was not at the door. I assumed he had gone to feed the chickens.

He had not, perhaps, been watching the light.

I dream tonight of my mother's house in Vinci. There is a child's hand on a door that should not open. The child is not me. The hand opens the door. The door opens onto a room I cannot describe because rooms in dreams do not stay still long enough to be described.

I wake once before dawn. The room is dark. Salai is still asleep. The shadow is nothing. The wrapped panel against the bench leg is a wrapped panel against a bench leg.

I lie awake until first grey.

SALAI WAKES FIRST. HE HAS ALWAYS WOKEN FIRST, EVEN IN WINTERS WHEN I have wanted him to sleep through. He sits up, runs a hand through his curls without untangling them, considers the day, and rises.

He crosses to the cabinet for his work-smock. He pulls the smock on over his shirt. He pauses. He looks down at it. He frowns. He shrugs his shoulders, twice. The smock does not give.

“Maestro,” he says. “Do you have a larger one? This is no longer mine.”

I lift my head from the pallet.

Salai is standing in the morning light. The light from the high window is pale and Lombard-grey. His curls catch it the way his curls have caught it since he was thirteen. The smock is taut across his shoulders, the seam showing strain at the back. He has grown. He has been growing for two years; I have been gone, or distracted, or working; and his shoulders are no longer the shoulders of the boy I dressed in this smock the autumn before last.

I have not painted him recently.

The child I fed for seven years is becoming a man. I have not yet looked at him long enough to see who that man is.

“In the cabinet,” I say. “Bottom shelf. The grey one.”

He turns. He goes to the cabinet. He comes back wearing one of my older smocks, too long in the body and too wide in the chest. He does not look ridiculous. He looks like an artist.

He looks like an artist who is becoming a man.

The two are not the same. I have known this longer than I have wanted to.

He comes to the bench. The wrapped panel is still against the leg, face to the wood. The box is closed. The journal is on the bench. The seven pots are arranged on the cloth he laid out last night before sleep.

“Maestro.”

“Yes.”

“Did you sleep?”

“Briefly.”

“Did you decide anything in the night.”

“I decided we test the pigments today.”

He does not flinch. He does not ask which ones, in what order, or whether he is to be in the room when I do it. He picks up the blue pot, the one whose wax devours the light, and holds it for a moment in the morning grey. The corner of

his thumbnail is already stained the way an apprentice's thumbnail is always stained: ground walnut, lead-tin, the particular brown of the inside of an oyster.

He sets the blue pot back down on the cloth.

“All right,” he says. He tilts his head a little to the left, the way he does when he is choosing his words. “I will say this once, Maestro. Twice if you make me. Then we will not have to say it again. Today you may stand at the bench, and I may stand at the doorway, if that is the arrangement you require. I will stand at the doorway. I will not enjoy it. If at any point you decide to die in front of me, that is your business; you have spent years preparing for it, in your own way. But I am not going back to Florence, and I am not going back to Oreno, and I am not going down the stairs of this workshop until what is in your refectory is no longer in your refectory. Yes?”

I look at him.

He looks at me. He is not crying. He is, perhaps, daring himself not to cry.

He says one word.

“We.”

III. THE TESTING



“There are three pigments you may use. There are four you may not. The difference between the two lists is what the using costs.”

Antonio da Vinci, keeper’s journal

Leonardo da Vinci

Leonardo’s workshop, Corte Vecchia, Milan

Late February 1497

MORNING IS GREY. THE WINDOW ABOVE THE WORKBENCH SHOWS THE COLD colour I knew from the road back from Vinci, not the silver-grey of Florence but the wet-stone grey of Lombardy in late winter. Salai has lit the brazier and put water on for the muller.

“Salai.”

“Maestro.”

“You will stand at the doorway. Not closer.”

He stops mid-motion. The water for the muller becomes a small lake of refusal in the bowl he is holding.

“Maestro. No.”

“Salai. Listen. If something happens to me, you must be able to leave. You must be at the doorway, where you can leave. Promise me.”

“I am not promising.”

“Then I will not test.”

“You will. You will test in an hour, or you will test in two; you will test today either way, because today is the only day you have.” He sets the bowl down. He does not promise. He walks across the workshop, slowly, until he is at the doorway, and stands there with one shoulder against the frame, his weight on his right foot, his hands doing nothing.

His hands are twitching to come closer.

“I am at the doorway.”

“Thank you.”

I grind the blue. I have ground pigments my entire adult life; the muller on the porphyry stone has a sound I know the way a bricklayer knows the sound of his trowel. The pigment yields under the muller. The pigment becomes finer. The pigment incorporates the oil. The pigment behaves as pigment behaves.

This pigment grinds wrong.

It does not resist. It also does not yield. The texture under the muller has the consistency of something being ground by my hand but not for my hand, as though the grinding is being done with my muscles by another mind, as though I am a tool being borrowed for the moment of its use.

The colour develops on the stone. Blue. Blue like blue should be. Blue like *azzurro della Magna* never has been. Blue with depth.

I prepare a small panel. Four inches by four. Common pine, primed with gesso. I dip a small brush. I paint a square.

The square is a window into the wood.

Not through. *Into*. I can see the grain of the wood, the lay of its fibres, at a depth the panel does not have. The panel is half an inch thick. The depth in the painted square does not stop where the panel stops. There is wood below the wood.

Cold air rises from the square against my hand. I cover it with a cloth, the one Salai folded last night and laid out on the bench beside the pots, because

Salai had decided last night that today there would be cloths laid out, and that he would lay them.

I look at my fingers. Two of them have the blue on them, the thumb and the index. I cross to the basin and pour the hot water. I rub the stain. The stain does not lift. I try linseed. The stain does not lift. I try the harshest soap I have, the one I use to clean varnish off brushes, and the blue remains under my skin, beneath the surface, a property of who I am now and not a thing on me.

“Maestro.”

“It will not wash off.”

“I can see that.”

This is how walls are made, I think; and I do not say it aloud, because Salai is at the doorway, and he is not promising anything, and he is also not leaving.

WE EAT. SALAI HAS COME BACK FROM THE CANAL MARKETS WHILE I WAS washing my fingers, bringing yesterday’s bread, fresh oil, a hard cheese, and two small fish wrapped in vine leaves he found somewhere. The fish are too small for sale; the market would have thrown them back.

“They were going to feed them to a cat,” he says. “I asked which cat. The fishmonger could not produce one. I said the fish were mine by right of confusion.” He drizzles oil on the bread. “The fishmonger said I was a small Florentine demon. I told him I was a small Milanese demon, the Florentines being known throughout Lombardy for their incompetence at demonry. He laughed. Then he gave me the fish.”

The fish are good. The oil is good. The bread, having sat overnight, has settled into the kind of slightly hard slice that has more flavour than fresh bread does. We eat for some time without speaking.

“Did the blue hurt.”

“No.”

“Did the blue look back.”

“...No.”

“Then either it has not noticed you yet, or it has noticed you and is being

patient. Which one.”

I do not answer.

“Maestro. Which one.”

“I do not know.”

Salai cuts the fish with the small knife he has used to cut all of our food since he was twelve. The knife is too small for the fish. He cuts it carefully anyway.

“Good. Then we test the red. Both of us.”

“Salai.”

“You said three pigments. You will not finish three pigments alone. We have three days, perhaps, before whatever is in your refectory finds another way through the plaster, and you cannot do this alone. You are not to test red without me in the room. You are not to test gold without me in the room. We are doing this. You may decide which of us holds the panel and which of us holds the brush. You may not decide whether I am in the room.”

He does not raise his voice. He does not flinch when he says *gold*. His knife continues the work it has been doing since he was twelve.

“Salai. Listen.”

“I am listening.”

“The man in the box. The one whose face is turned to the wall.”

“Yes.”

“He had an apprentice. The journal does not say what happened to him.”

Salai chews. He swallows. He picks an olive from the bowl, the olives that have come back from yesterday with fresh oil over the old, and pulls the pit.

“Then we will find out, you and I. Yes?”

“Yes.”

He eats. I eat. We finish the fish and the bread and most of the oil. He pushes the dishes aside.

“After.”

“After what.”

“After the red.”

I GRIND THE RED.

The red grinds differently than the blue. The blue ground wrong because it did not yield. The red grinds wrong because it yields too eagerly. The pigment turns to paste in three strokes of the muller. The colour develops faster than red develops. The red wants to be ground. The red wants to be ready.

I do not like that the red wants anything.

“Maestro.”

Salai is at the bench. He has carried in a small panel of seasoned pine, primed yesterday by his own hand. He holds the panel at the corners. He has a clean cloth folded over his arm in case there is spill.

“You said the doorway.”

“I changed my mind.”

“You changed your mind.”

“One drop. You hold the panel. I apply.”

“One drop.”

I prepare the brush, the smallest I have for tempera detail work, with a tip of perhaps four hairs. I dip. I lift one drop of red.

The drop hangs from the brush. It is too dark to be red. It is the colour of the inside of a wound an hour after the cut.

I touch the brush to the panel.

The drop transfers. The panel weeps.

Not in the way paint weeps when applied to imperfectly sized wood. Not by capillary action. The drop spreads with a small visible motion of its own, the way ink spreads on paper but slower, and *aimed*. It carves a slit in the wood. A small slit, perhaps half an inch long, in the place where the drop had been. The slit is wet.

The slit speaks.

The voice is not the voice from the refectory wall. The voice from the refectory wall has been a critic, articulate, a connoisseur of composition. This voice is a woman's: older, tired, the voice of a woman who has worked hard and loved a child and is calling that child from across a kitchen and a distance.

Salaino.

Salai's eyes go to the panel.

Salaino. Little dirty one. Little devil. The name his mother gave him. The name he answers to in the workshop. The name she would have called him from the kitchen of the small house outside Oreno where she worked as a servant.

The voice says one more word.

Caterina.

The name is his mother's name. The name is also my mother's name. The doubling does not register on his face; it registers on the inside of my chest, which is the cleverness of the voice, which has chosen the one syllable that catches both of us.

Salai drops the panel.

The panel hits the bench with the sound of any board hitting any bench. The red continues to spread. The slit lengthens. The wood begins to flex along the grain the way a small fish flexes when you set it down on a counter. The board is breathing.

"Maestro."

Salai has stepped back. He has stepped back, but he has not turned around. He has not run. He is, perhaps, daring himself not to run the way last night at the bench he dared himself not to cry.

"Salai."

I have the palette knife already. I do not remember picking it up. I scrape. I scrape hard. The red comes up reluctantly, in long thin curls. The wood beneath is wet, soft, the colour of something that has been a tree perhaps two days ago. I scrape until I see clean wood. I scrape past clean wood.

I notice, scraping, that my hand is bleeding.

I notice this the way one notices a missing word at the end of a half-remembered sentence. The hand is wet. The wet is not red pigment. The wet is brighter than the red pigment. The palette knife has cut my palm somewhere in the scraping, and I have not felt the cut, and the red on the panel has pulled my blood toward it across the grain, and the red is drinking.

My throat has stopped working.

Salai is staring at the panel; he does not see my hand. The blood is on the

underside of the panel where he cannot see. I find words eventually. They come out clipped, as if from a body that is breathing in narrow.

“The blue. Quickly. Cover this.”

Salai moves. He has the blue pot in his hands before I finish the sentence. He scrapes blue onto a brush, the larger brush, the coarse one we use for ground coats. He paints. He paints over the red, over the slit, over the bleeding wood. The blue settles over the red the way water settles over a fire that has begun to die.

The blue does what the blue is for.

The voice goes silent. The wood stops breathing. The slit closes under the blue, sealed not by physical adhesion but by something I will not be able to describe to anyone who has not used the blue. The blue makes a wall. I felt it as it happened; the blue made a wall between the surface of the wood and what was on the other side of the wood, and what was on the other side of the wood was the same thing that was on the other side of the plaster at Santa Maria delle Grazie.

Salai turns to me. He sees my hand. His face does what his face does when he is afraid and refusing to show me he is afraid.

“Maestro.”

“It will close.”

“It will not close.”

He has the cloth he had folded over his arm. He wraps my hand without asking. He works fast. He ties the cloth tight; he does not meet my eyes.

“Maestro.”

“Yes.”

“She used her name. My mother’s name.”

“And mine.”

He stops. He has not heard that. He has not, for the four seconds it takes him to comprehend it, known that his mother and mine share a name. He looks at me. He looks at the panel. He looks back at me.

“*Both* our mothers.”

“Yes.”

“She is using both of them.”

“Yes.”

Salai sits down on the floor of the workshop, against the leg of the workbench, on the side opposite the wrapped panel. He sits down hard. He does not cry. He does what he did last night when I had decided we would test the pigments today: he begins, after a moment, to laugh.

It is a small laugh. It is not amused.

“Maestro. We are in trouble.”

“Yes.”

The red is for life. And life knows what it is hungry for.

LATE AFTERNOON. THE BANDAGE ON MY HAND IS HEAVIER THAN IT WAS; SALAI has changed it twice. The cut continues to weep small amounts of slow blood, dark and ordinary.

We do not test red again. We do not need to. The board the red opened is now under two coats of blue, leaning against the back wall of the workshop, where it can see no one and no one can see it. Salai has not looked at it in two hours.

He brings me a fragment of plaster from the small pile by the door, the pieces that fell when the carpenter built the new shelves last summer, plaster Salai has been meaning to clear away for six months. The fragment is the size of a child’s palm.

I open the gold pot.

The pot is colder than it should be. It is colder than the cold pot was this morning. There is frost on the seal, frost that did not exist when I opened the box last night, frost that has formed during a day in a heated workshop. The frost is white against the red wax.

Salai stands back. He has learned, today, when to stand back.

I break the seal. The pot is not gold; the gold is. The pot is a small clay vessel containing what looks at first like ground gilt and reveals itself, when I tilt it toward the lamp, as a powder finer than any gilt I have ever ground, with light

coming off it the way light comes off a mirror tilted just so. The light is not the lamp's. The light is the gold's own.

I scrape a small amount of gold onto a brush. I paint a single line on the plaster fragment. One line. One stroke. Perhaps two inches long. The gold lies on the plaster as gold lies on plaster, except for the small private fact that the gold is glowing.

I say one word.

"Leonardo."

The plaster says it back.

The voice is my own voice. Exactly my own voice. The pitch. The slight rasp from too little sleep. The particular way the *o* sounds in my mouth, which is a Florentine *o* and not a Milanese *o*. The plaster has just spoken my name in my voice.

The plaster says it again.

"Leonardo. Soon."

I did not say *soon*.

Salai's hand goes to the chisel on the bench. He has been waiting, perhaps, for the moment when the chisel will be needed. He brings it down on the plaster fragment. He brings it down again. He brings it down a third time. The plaster is dust on the floor.

He stands looking at the dust.

"Maestro," he says, without lifting his eyes. "Did you hear?"

"Yes."

"The second word. Was that yours?"

"No."

"Yours is *now*. You always say *now*. You have never said *soon* in your life."

"I know."

"Then whose was that?"

"Mine."

He looks at me.

"Mine," I say, "in the way the panel was your mother's voice and not your mother. It used my mouth. It practised the *o*."

We sweep the dust into the brazier. The dust burns blue, not orange. Not the colour ordinary plaster dust burns. The dust burns the colour of the blue pigment I painted onto the slit this morning, the colour of the wall the blue makes.

I seal the gold pot. The frost on the seal has not gone, even after the pot has stood open in a heated room. Salai watches me seal it. He watches the brazier where the blue dust is still burning faintly along one log.

He does not say what he is thinking. I know what he is thinking. He is thinking that the gold takes what is given to it and gives it back, and is therefore the colour of binding. We have learned this without being told.

NIGHT.

Salai has been asleep for an hour. The brazier is banked. The bandage on my hand has soaked through to a soft brown, and for some time now I have been meaning to lift my head from the pallet and change it.

I have not lifted my head.

I am in a gallery.

I was not in a gallery the moment before. I do not remember closing my eyes. The gallery is vaulted, long, lit by oil lamps in iron sconces. The ceiling has the high arched echo of the refectory at Santa Maria delle Grazie. The walls are stone, and the walls hold paintings.

Paintings on both walls, paintings hung close. Some I recognise: my own *Annunciation* from when I was twenty, the unfinished Adoration that sits in Florence as a brown ghost. Some I do not. A Crucifixion in the manner of nothing I have seen, by a hand that worked with light the way I work with light, except where I would have laid a glaze the painter has laid a void; the place where Christ's face should be is, in this Crucifixion, the place where the wall is. Beside it, a portrait of a young woman with a single eye larger than the other, painted as if to be looked at by someone who would not notice that it was wrong. An *Annunciation* by a different hand, with the angel's wings spread in a geometry I cannot account for.

The unfamiliar paintings are accomplished. They are the work of people who

could paint.

They are the work of keepers.

I walk the length of the gallery. The lamps burn rancid; I smell tallow that has gone past use, the sour smell of a candle burning to the wick. The paintings are hung in chronological order. I know this because I can date the techniques: the earliest is a Byzantine icon, then an early Tuscan Madonna in the manner of Cimabue, then a Sienese altarpiece. Each of them shows the same thing, the same small private wrongness, in a different style. A door painted into a wall that should be solid. A figure rendered in a pose that almost makes sense. A face with a smile no painter would render except by mistake.

Seven paintings. There are seven paintings. I count them as I walk.

Maestro.

She is at the far end of the gallery. She does not approach. I cannot see her clearly; the light at her end is dimmer.

Your Christ's left hand.

I turn. My own *Cenacolo* is on the wall beside me, smaller than its real proportions but recognisable.

You have set it palm-up. Open. Generous. This is wrong. He has just said: one of you will betray me. His hand should be closed. Or, better, pointing. The composition does not bear his openness. You have made him too gentle for the moment.

She is correct.

The apostles. Arranged as a frieze. Look. Three, three, Christ, three, three. You are too symmetrical, Maestro. Real men do not cluster in symmetries. They overlap. They lean. You have made them obedient to the wall behind them.

She is correct again.

And Judas. Judas you have not finished because you do not know what he is. You are too kind to him. You imagine a moneylender. A cruel man. A simple narrative. Judas is not a cruel man. Let me show you what he is.

On the wall beside the unfinished *Cenacolo*, a new painting appears. A face. The face is of a kind man, a man with the soft eyes of someone who has loved his teacher very much, a man whose betrayal would be the more terrible because

of the love.

The face is correct. The face is exactly what Judas should be.

Dimmi: what does it mean that her composition is better than mine?

Yes, she says, as if the dream has read me too. *I can teach you composition, Maestro. I can show you how to make the apostles cluster. I can finish your bronze horse, the one that will be melted in two years for cannon by men who do not know what bronze is for. I can give you Judas. Together, you and I, could complete the work of your life.*

“What is the price.”

The dream-room is silent for a long moment.

What it has always been, Maestro. The same price your grandfather refused to pay.

I look at the seven paintings. I look back to the far end of the gallery, where she stands or does not stand.

“And what did the other seven pay.”

She does not answer. The dimness at her end of the gallery deepens.

The eighth frame, the one nearest her, is not yet filled. The frame is there. The wall behind the frame is the wall.

Soon, she says, and the word is in my own voice, the way the plaster said it this afternoon. Soon you will hang here. Beside the others. Your face will be the eighth.

I wake. I wake the way a man wakes from drowning. Salai is already at my pallet. His hand is on the back of my neck; his other hand is steadying the wooden bowl he has placed in front of me. I empty my stomach into the bowl. The bowl smells of bile and the wine from dinner. I am shaking. I have been shaking since the scaffolding.

“Maestro.”

“I am here.”

“Was she.”

“Yes.”

“What did she say.”

I look at Salai. His face is very young and very awake in the brazier light.

The line of his jaw is the line of the boy who climbed those stairs at ten. The line is changing. I have not stopped to watch it change.

“She knows my work better than I do. And she is collecting us.”

DAWN COMES SLOWLY. WE HAVE NOT SLEPT SINCE THE DREAM. WE SIT AT THE workbench. The wrapped panel is between us, still wrapped, still tied with my grandfather’s country knot, which I retied last night because there was nothing else to do with my hands.

Salai works it out.

“We need to seal both prisons at once.”

“Yes.”

“Tell me the geometry.”

“You and I, both of us at once. I paint Judas. You paint the portrait.”

“You have been failing at Judas for seven months.”

“Yes. And tonight I will not fail at Judas. Because tonight Judas will not be looking out.”

“Eyes inward.”

“Toward Peter’s knife. The gaze that would open the door is held inside the painting. The door cannot open while the gaze is held.”

He nods slowly.

“And the portrait.”

“You paint the portrait. The small one. The wrapped one. At the same moment. Same gesture. We bind both prisons in the same act.”

“With the gold.”

“With the gold. Last. Both panels.”

“This will cost us.”

“Yes.”

“Tonight.”

“Tonight.”

He puts both his palms flat on the bench in front of him and looks at his own hands. His hands have not yet been stained. He notices this. He looks at my two

blue fingertips. He looks at the bandage on my palm. He looks at his own clean hands, the hands of a seventeen-year-old who has not yet paid anything.

“Maestro.”

“Yes.”

“When I paint the portrait. With the gold. Will I be the one paying.”

He has worked it out himself. He should not be able to. He is not a keeper. He should not be able.

“Yes. Both of us. Each paying what the work demands of the painter.”

“Good.”

“Salai.”

“It is good, Maestro. I would rather pay than be unable to help you.”

He looks at me then.

“I have not been a good apprentice.”

“Salai.”

“I have stolen from you, lied to you, and traded your second-best brushes for wine on three documented occasions, possibly more. I have been *il Salaino*. I have been the little devil. Today I am going to be the man who paints the portrait. Will you let me be the man who paints the portrait.”

I do not say yes. He does not need me to.

WE WILL NOT SLEEP BEFORE THE RITUAL. WE LIE DOWN ANYWAY.

The body needs rest. The mind refuses. The mind is composing every gesture of what we are about to do, every stroke, every brush, every order in which the pots will be opened and closed. The mind is also, separately, composing my mother’s face. I have been looking at her face in memory since the dream, the way one looks at something to confirm it is still there. The face is still there. I do not know if it will be there tomorrow.

Leonardo on his pallet. Salai on his. The brazier between us, low. The bandage on my hand is wet. I changed it three hours ago; it is wet again. The cut has decided what it is going to be. It is going to be a thing that remembers.

Salai reaches across the gap between the pallets. His hand finds mine. The

bandage is damp under his fingers. He does not say anything about the damp. He does not let go.

“Maestro.”

“Yes.”

“If your mother and my mother share a name, then we share something I had not yet decided whether to claim.”

“Salai.”

“I claim it.”

“It is not a thing one claims. It is a thing one finds out one is.”

“Then I have found out.”

I do not answer. The brazier hisses. One coal fails. The cold creeps up through the floor toward us, the wet Lombard cold that gets in at the ankles first.

We do not let go. We do not sleep.

The day does not pass. It thickens. The bells mark Prime, then Terce, then Sext, then None, each office arriving from the lower city as if time still believes itself useful. The bells mean nothing to us except that the dark is coming.

The bandage is damp. Salai’s hand is over the bandage. We wait.

IV. THE PRICE OF DOORS



“The keeper does not save what he protects. The keeper pays for it instead.”
Antonio da Vinci, final entry in the journal

Leonardo da Vinci
Leonardo’s workshop, Corte Vecchia & Refectory of Santa Maria delle Grazie,
Milan
Late February 1497

WE LEAVE THE WORKSHOP AT THE THIRD HOUR AFTER SUNSET.

Salai carries the wrapped panel against his chest, the cord retied in my grandfather’s country knot. I carry the wooden box with the seven pots, the small lamp, two extra brushes, a flask of linseed against the cold, and a stoppered jar of mulled wine I do not intend to drink. The streets of Milan after dark are not the streets they are by daylight. By daylight Milan is a city. By dark Milan is a series of small lit rooms separated by alleys in which one does not walk if one prefers to keep one’s purse.

We walk. Salai goes ahead. He knows these alleys; he has known them since he was eight, in the years before he was an apprentice, when he was a boy on the

Naviglio earning a piece of bread by carrying the fishmonger's basket. The watch-fires of the city guard burn at the corners. The dogs at Sant'Eustorgio bark twice and stop. The cold comes off the canal and into the lungs as a separate weight.

Salai does not speak. I do not speak.

We reach Santa Maria delle Grazie at perhaps the fourth hour. The cloister is empty. The monks are at compline; I can hear their voices, distant, through the connecting wall, the late Office sung by men who do not yet know what is in the refectory three doors away from them.

I take my key from my belt. The lock turns. The iron clicks. We are in.

The refectory is colder than the cloister. The plaster by the Judas-space has the particular cold of plaster that has been waiting for a thing.

Salai sets the wrapped panel on the workbench I had Marco bring in last summer and which Marco has now abandoned. He unties the cord. He folds the linen. He turns the panel face-up.

The face is still wrong. The face still has the half-yawn that lives between expressions, and after two days under linen on my workbench the face has not aged.

"Maestro."

"Salai."

"It is looking at us."

"It has always been looking at us."

He does not flinch this time. He has been preparing himself for this for two days and a night. He lifts the small bench-lamp I gave him to carry and sets it so that the panel is lit from the same angle as the wall above us, the same light, the same shadow plane. He has thought about this. He has thought about it without telling me.

He removes his coat. Beneath it he is wearing the grey smock from yesterday morning, the one too long in the body and too wide in the chest, the one that makes him look like an artist becoming a man.

He picks up a brush. He looks across the refectory at me. The look is the one I used to give my master Verrocchio when I was sixteen, on the day he handed

me the unfinished angel in the *Baptism of Christ* and said: *finish it. I have other work.*

I nod.

We begin.

THE REFECTORY IS A LONG ROOM, VAULTED, WITH THE LONG TABLE RUNNING ITS length and the great Christ on the wall at the head. The scaffolding I have been working from for two years stands against the wall to the right of the table. Salai's bench is set against the left wall, where the light from the bench-lamp can reach the small panel without compromising my own.

We have set up the room so that he is in my peripheral vision and I am in his.

I climb the scaffolding. Each rung feels longer tonight. By the third rung my left knee tells me what my body has been telling me since the road back from Vinci, that it knows what is coming, and that it does not approve. By the fifth rung I am at the level of the apostles' shoulders, and I can see Salai below me, at the bench, the small lamp lit, the panel face-up on a folded cloth.

The Judas-space waits.

I have not looked at the Judas-space at this hour, in this light, before tonight. The space is darker than the surrounding plaster, by which I mean: the surrounding plaster reflects the lamp, and the Judas-space does not.

Maestro.

Her voice. In the wall. Through the wall. From the panel below. She is in both. She is in the room.

You are about to ruin my evening.

It is a joke. Her voice is making a joke. The voice I heard a week ago could not have made a joke. The voice has been practising. The voice has been getting closer.

Let us bargain.

I do not answer. I prepare my brushes. I have brought four: the smallest, for the irises of the eyes; the middle, for the contours; the larger, for the broad fill of cheek and neck; and a fourth, a flat, for gold.

Maestro. I will not be subtle. Listen.

I dip the first brush in the underpainting, the red ochre I have ground from regular pigment, the safe pigment from the cabinet of my Milan studio, not from my grandfather's box. I will not use the seven pots on the underpainting. I will use them only at the moment of the eyes, the moment of the mouth, the moment of the sealing.

To you, Maestro. I offer your bronze horse. I offer the Adoration. I offer the diving apparatus, the flying machine, the mechanical lion, the city of Imola redrawn on perfect maps. I offer everything you have begun and not finished. I will finish them in your hand. You will be the only painter and engineer in history whose work was completed.

I lay the underpainting on Judas's cheek. The ochre takes. The brush behaves.

To the boy. Salaino. I offer your mother. The version of her you remember from before she gave you up. The kitchen at Oreno. The smell of bread. The dress with the blue stitching at the wrist. I will give them all back.

Salai's brush pauses. For a heartbeat. Then he continues. The ochre takes. The brush behaves.

You are not listening, she says.

We do not answer.

The voice changes register. The voice has been the critic and the tempter; now it is the buyer who has decided the merchant is wasting her time.

Then I will tell you the cost of refusing me, and I will speak plainly because you have not earned politeness. Maestro: your Cenacolo will not survive the century. The plaster you have insisted on for this painting is wrong for fresco, and the painting will begin to peel within twenty years. I have known this since you laid the first coat. I have permitted it. I will withdraw my permission tonight, and the painting will not survive fifty.

She is correct about the plaster. I know this. I have known it since I chose it.

And the boy. Salaino. The boy is not yours and never will be. He will leave you for a French king and he will marry and he will die before he is fifty, in a way I would have spared him from. I have seen this. It is on the wall behind me.

I look down. Salai is painting. His brush moves. He has heard her. He is not looking up.

Maestro.

“No.”

Maestro.

“No.”

The voice becomes patient again. The patience now is the patience of a thing settling in for a longer fight.

Very well. Begin. I will be here.

I take up the brush. I begin Judas’s eye.

I PAINT.

The underpainting goes on the cheekbones, the brow, the hollow under the eye, the soft place beneath the lip. I render Judas as my grandfather rendered faces: green-brown under the flesh, the way Florentine masters laid the ground in the last century. This is not how I would paint Judas in a normal commission. This is how a keeper paints. I learned the technique by reading my grandfather’s journal twice in the last forty hours.

Below me Salai paints.

Salai is rendering Famelica. He has, on the bench beside the lamp, Antonio’s cracked prison-panel; he is not making a copy of it. He is painting *over* it, completing what my grandfather left half-finished, renewing the binding where the prison has cracked. The same panel. The same prison. New gold to seal what the old gold could no longer hold.

The smell in the room is wrong. The smell of fresh pigment in a room should be linseed and walnut oil with the slight base note of the binder. The smell tonight is the same plus something I do not have a word for, the smell of a place becoming a different place. I have stopped trying to identify the second smell. I am painting through it.

The voice has not yet returned.

Maestro.

There. There is the voice. The voice is closer.

I lift the second brush. I begin the mid-tones of Judas's flesh. The skin of the face begins to develop on the wall in front of me, in the place where the seventeen Judases failed, and as the face develops I understand for the first time why it failed seventeen times.

Dimmi: why has the face failed seventeen times?

It failed because I was painting a man. The face is not a man; the face is a key, the shape of the lock the door is set in. The face has the proportions of a man because the door needs a man-shaped key to hold it shut. I have been trying to paint a *character*. The wall has been waiting for a *function*.

I paint the function.

The face develops on the wall as the seventeenth attempt would have developed if I had let it dry. The face that came through under the wet pigment that afternoon and made me reach for the palette knife, that face, is the face I am now painting on purpose. The same face. The same mouth. The same calm, ordinary, decided expression of a small functionary at his master's table.

I am painting her Judas.

I understand this as I paint. The terror of understanding it does not stop my hand; my hand has gone past terror into the place beyond terror, the place where the body works because the body has been told to work and no longer asks for permission.

Yes, Maestro, she says, quietly. Yes. This is the face.

"Salai. The portrait."

"I have her, Maestro. I have her halfway. The mouth is the difficult part."

"The eyes last. Same moment. Mine and yours."

"Yes."

The lamp on the bench sputters. The flame on the scaffolding lamp sputters. Both lamps are burning low. Both will go before midnight.

Salai paints the mouth. The mouth on the portrait is exactly the mouth I have heard since the scaffolding, soft, intelligent, slightly amused. He has heard her too. He has put the amusement on the mouth.

You hear me well, Salaino. You paint me well. You will make a magnificent

keeper.

Salai's brush pauses. Holds.

"Salai. Do not listen."

"I am not listening, Maestro."

"You paused."

"I paused because the mouth required pausing. I am painting her mouth, not the mouth of the voice."

He is lying. He paused because she said *keeper*. He paused because he heard, in the word, the weight of his own future. I do not say so. He needs to keep painting. The mouth has to be finished before the eyes.

The mouth is finished. The two faces are now almost complete. Mine on the wall, his on the panel. Both are missing the eyes.

THE REFECTORY DOOR BANGS OPEN.

Not unlocked. Bangs. The iron handle on the inside of the door clatters once as the outside push catches the latch wrong; the inside latch I locked an hour ago has held against three pulls and now gives on the fourth, the wood splintering at the housing. Bandello has used the spare key with insufficient patience.

He stands in the door.

He is in a white woollen night-robe over a dark tunic, the slippers of a man who has come straight from his cell. He has a lamp. He has also a small leather strap I think is the prior's discipline-strap and which he has perhaps picked up out of confused instinct. He smells of incense and the bitter herb the Dominicans drink at compline against the cold.

He sees me on the scaffolding. He sees Salai at the bench. He sees the half-painted face on the wall in the lamplight, and he sees the half-painted face on the panel.

"Maestro Leonardo..."

He stops mid-sentence.

His face does the thing a face does when it has just calibrated the situation against what the situation cannot be. It is a small adjustment, the size of a

knuckle, but I have watched faces my whole life and I see his face make it.

“What in the name of God...”

“Father, please. Step back. Step back into the cloister.”

It is Salai’s voice. Salai has come off the bench, brush still in his hand. The portrait on the bench is unfinished. Salai is between Bandello and the door, between Bandello and me, between Bandello and the wall. He is also taller than Bandello by half a hand and broader than Bandello by a shoulder, and he is seventeen and the Prior is sixty-two.

“Boy. Get out of my way.”

“Father. With respect. Step back.”

“That is *vandalism*. He is, what is he...”

The Prior takes a step into the room. Toward the wall.

The Judas-space pulses.

Bandello sees it. Bandello sees what cannot be there. His face does another small calibration. This one is larger.

“*Madre di Dio*.”

“Father. Outside. Please.”

Salai puts a hand on Bandello’s shoulder. Not violent. Not unkind. The hand of an apprentice asking a master to step away from a kiln. The Prior shakes him off; he comes another step into the room; my hand on the scaffolding has already taken up the next brush, the smallest brush, the brush for the iris of the eye. I dip into the gold pot. I cannot wait. I begin the eye.

I begin the eye, and my hand slips.

It does not slip much. It slips the width of one hair of the brush. The iris of Judas’s eye, which was meant to look inward toward Peter’s knife, has been laid with the pupil a hair’s breadth too far toward the left of the iris. The eye is now looking outward. Toward the viewer.

The room exhales.

She is through.

She is in the room.

Not as a voice. Not as a presence. As a *displacement*. The air of the refectory becomes the air of somewhere else, and for one second the smell I had no word

for has a word, the smell is the smell of a thing that eats the inside of a wall and has waited eighty-three years to eat what is on the outside of one.

Salai screams once.

The Prior screams the longer scream. The Prior is on his knees on the marble of the refectory, the discipline-strap fallen from his hand, and he is reciting the Office of the Dead in a Latin that has lost most of its syntax.

I have no palette knife. I left it at the workshop. I have the brush, and I have my hand.

I scrape the gold from the iris with my fingernail.

The nail splits. The blood comes. The gold lifts. The eye is plaster again, raw, scoured, ready. I redip the brush, and I lay the iris a second time, and this time my hand does not slip, and the pupil sits in the iris as it ought to sit, and the eye of the painted Judas turns inward and looks at Peter's knife.

The door begins to close.

She makes a sound I will not describe in this journal. She makes the sound an animal makes when the trap closes on the leg it had thought it could pull free.

Salai is at the bench. He has not stopped painting. He has the brush for his portrait. He is laying the iris of her painted eye now, the same moment, the same gesture. He paints. He paints. He paints.

The eye of the portrait opens. The eye looks at us. The eye is hers.

THE COST BEGINS.

I do not feel it the way I had imagined I would feel it. I had imagined pain. I had imagined sickness. I had imagined the body's protest against something taken from it. What I feel instead is *quiet*. Specific small quiet. The kind of quiet a room takes on when a clock that has been ticking for some time stops ticking.

In my mind, my mother stands in a Tuscan summer-courtyard. She lifts me. She is twenty-three years old. The sun is on the back of her neck. She turns her face toward mine. She is smiling, the small smile she gave me only when no one else was watching, the smile that was for the two of us.

Her face begins to soften.

Not blur. *Soften*. The way wax softens before melting. The contours of her cheek, the bridge of her nose, the place where her eyes met her brow, the geometry begins to lose its precision. I try, on the scaffolding, with the brush still in my hand, with the gold still wet on Judas's iris, to hold her face in my mind. I hold for a heartbeat. Two. I hold by sheer will. The image continues to soften.

When I let her go, she has the dimensions of a face but no features.

I will not get her back. I am paying.

On the bench, Salai paints. The portrait's eye is open now. The other eye is forming. Salai's hand is steady. His face has done something I do not have a name for. He has stopped blinking. He blinks now twice, in quick succession, as if testing whether blinking still does what blinking should do.

He looks at the lamp. He looks at his brush. He looks at the small jar of blue beside the gold.

"Maestro," he says, very quietly. "The blue."

"What about the blue."

"The blue is not blue."

"Salai..."

"The blue, Maestro, is grey. The jar is grey. The bench is grey. The flame is the colour of the flame. The wood is the colour of the wood. The blue is grey."

He is paying. He keeps painting.

The portrait's second eye opens. Salai paints it without looking down at the panel; he is looking at the wall, at me, at the lamp, at anything that will tell him the colour blue is somewhere else in the room.

I want to climb down. I want to be at his shoulder. I cannot. The work is not done. We have eyes; we do not yet have the sealing gold. The sealing gold must be the last stroke. It has to be the same stroke. Both of us at once.

We carried it to the refectory.

I remember Salai's hands around the linen at the corners of the panel as we crossed the cloister. I remember him setting the panel on the bench. I remember him untying the cord, folding the linen, lifting the wrapping away.

But the cord is still tied. I see it from the scaffolding. The country knot my grandfather taught me at six is intact on the panel below.

The panel on the bench is the one Salai has been painting all night.

Both are true.

The room has had the panel the whole time. The room is also receiving the panel we carried from the workshop. Memory is the cost. The memory is going. I am inside the going.

I find the brush in my hand. I find the gold. I find Salai's eyes, across the room, looking up at me.

"Now."

"Now."

WE PAINT THE SEAL.

The seal is the gold on the eyelashes. Not the iris. The lashes. The line of fine gold that holds the eye closed when the door wants to open. We have understood this in the last quarter-hour from a journal page neither of us has read; we have understood it because we are keeping, and the keeping is teaching us as we go.

I paint the lashes of Judas's left eye. Salai paints the lashes of Famelica's right eye. We move at the same rate. We breathe at the same rate. The two faces, his small one on the bench, mine large on the wall, develop the gold line at the same moment.

The Prior is silent on the marble. He has finished the Office of the Dead. He has begun a Psalm I do not recognise; the words are Latin but the rhythm is his own, the way a frightened man recites when he can no longer remember the verses he was taught and is making the cadence up by feel. He is not looking at us; he is looking at the floor, at the small worn place on the marble where the procession of monks has placed its feet for two hundred years.

I finish Judas's lashes. Salai finishes Famelica's.

Then, because the mouth is how she spoke, Salai draws one fine thread of gold along the seam of her painted lips. The line is so thin it is almost not a line. The line is the difference between a mouth that can open and a mouth that cannot. He lifts the brush; the gold sets; the seam holds.

There is one more gesture. Salai sets down the small brush and lifts the flat one, the wider brush we use for ground coats. He dips it in the gold. He lays four lines along the four edges of the small panel: top first, then right, then bottom, then left. Each line is a single unbroken stroke, the way the gilders of Florence paint a frame. The gold sets the boundary. The gold tells the prison where it ends.

He finishes with the lower-left corner.

My wall has its frame already. The architecture of the *Cenacolo* is its own painted frame; the lunettes, the painted pilasters, the ceiling-coffers I designed at the beginning of this work. Gold along an edge of the wall is not needed. The wall is its own gilt.

The room becomes quiet.

The quiet is not the quiet of an empty room. The quiet is the quiet of a room that has just been entered by no one, the quiet a room has after a door that has been open all winter has finally closed.

Maestro.

Her voice. Different. Diminished. Coming through the gold rather than around it.

Did you notice the eyes?

I look at the wall.

The eyes of my painted Judas are looking inward, toward Peter's knife. The gaze is held. The door is sealed.

But beneath the gold, in the iris of the left eye, I have left a small mark. A tiny smudge. The hair-breadth slip from earlier, which I scraped with my fingernail, has left a faint discoloration that the gold has covered but not erased. The mark is not visible to anyone who does not know it is there. The mark is visible to her, and to me, and now to Salai, who has come down from the bench and is standing at the foot of the scaffolding looking up.

Did you notice the eyes, Maestro?

"I have noticed."

The door is closed. But the door is not perfectly closed. A door imperfectly closed is a door that can be opened.

“I know.”

Not tonight. Not next year. But.

“I know.”

We will meet again, Maestro. You. And the boy. And whoever you teach next. We will meet again because the gold has dried over a flaw, and the flaw will be there as long as the gold is there, and the gold will be there as long as your wall stands, and your wall will not stand as long as you have promised the Dominicans it will. I have all the time, Maestro. I have all the time.

The voice fades. The voice does not vanish; the voice fades. The voice is now behind a wall I have spent my entire night building.

I let go of the brush.

The brush falls from the scaffolding. The brush hits the marble. The brush makes the sound a brush makes when a brush hits marble. Not a bell. A brush.

Salai is below me. He is looking up at me. His face is in the lamplight; he has caught the lamplight with his left eye, and his left eye is doing the small thing eyes do when an eye is no longer seeing all the colours an eye used to see.

“Maestro,” he says. “Come down. Please.”

I come down.

WE ARE ALIVE.

We sit on the floor of the refectory, against the wall opposite the Cenacolo. The marble is cold under us; the cold goes through the wool of my smock and the wool of his and finds the wet places on my hand where the blood has not yet stopped. Salai’s left hand is on my left wrist. He has not taken it off in some minutes. I have not asked him to.

The Prior has gone. I did not see him leave. He left some time during the sealing, in a silence I had not heard happen, while I was finishing the lashes. The discipline-strap is still on the floor where he dropped it. The door of the refectory is open; the cold air of the cloister is in the room. I do not know what he will say, or to whom; I know only what I saw on his face when he saw what cannot be there, and a man whose face has done that does not, in my experience,

speak of it.

Outside, the bells have begun the Office of Lauds. The monks are awake. They will be in their stalls; they will not come to the refectory until the breakfast hour. We have perhaps two hours before they find us.

The wall is dry.

I have looked at it twice since coming down. The Judas is finished. The Judas's gaze is held. The composition closes around him in the way I had refused for fourteen months to let it close. He is unmistakable as Judas. He is also unmistakable as the man I would have painted if I had been a better painter and a worse man. The wall, as a painting, will be considered a masterpiece by men who do not know what is sealed beneath the gold of the left eye.

The portrait is on the bench.

The portrait is the face of a woman I have never seen and now will see in dreams for the rest of my life. Her expression is calm, intelligent, slightly amused. Her eyes are the eyes of a thing that has agreed to wait. The portrait will go back to Vinci with me; I will carry it the way my grandfather carried his seven failed predecessors with him, in their failures, in his life-record, until the moment he gave the box to my father with instructions to give it to me.

I will, when I am older, paint another. I do not yet know this. The painting I will paint will not be of her. The painting will be of a woman I have not yet met, though her smile is already finding its way toward me. The painting will, however, be of the same thing. I will not understand this until I am dying. I will understand many things only when I am dying.

"Salai."

"Maestro."

"Your eye."

"My left. The blue is gone. The other colours are mostly. The light is bright on that side. I will manage."

"Salai. I am sorry."

He is quiet for a while.

"I am not sorry."

"Salai..."

“I am not. I had a clean hand last night. Tonight I have a useful hand. The hand that painted her eyes is the hand that will paint everything I paint for the rest of my life. It is a better hand than the hand I had last night.”

He turns his head to look at me. The left eye, the one that has lost the blue, has a fineness to it I have not seen before; it is the eye of a man who knows what he is looking at, because he has paid for what he is looking at.

“Maestro. I remember loving you.”

I do not answer. I cannot. The face of my mother is gone, and I cannot give her face back to him, and there is no word in my body that is large enough for what he has just said. I take his hand.

He says it again, not because he needs to, but because he has decided this is a thing he is going to be able to say.

“I remember loving you.”

We sit on the cold marble.

Outside, the bells continue.

Tomorrow, we will begin pretending nothing happened.

EPILOGUE



“The work is never over. The work is only inherited again.”
Antonio da Vinci, opening of the keeper’s journal

Leonardo da Vinci
A rented workshop, Florence
Spring 1502

THE COMPASS REFUSES TO DRAW A TRUE CIRCLE.

I have tried three times this morning. The radius is set. The legs are tight. The Florentine paper under my hand is good Fabriano stock, smooth, ground with bone in the proper old method. The compass-point holds its centre, the drawing-point follows the arc, and the arc drifts.

It drifts by perhaps a hair, perhaps less. The drift is consistent; the drift is the same on each attempt; the drift is small enough that no other man working in this room would notice it. I notice it. Such things were once the simplest measurements my hand could make.

A circle, for me, was once the simplest thing the hand could do. The wrist remembered the radius. The shoulder kept the plane. The mind did not have to

participate. The line closed itself.

The line no longer closes itself.

The fourth attempt does not close either. I set the compass down. I pick it up. I set it down again. I look at my left hand. The hand is fifty-one next April. The hand still has the two blue fingertips; the blue has not faded. The bandaged cut across the palm is now a thin red line that has not faded either. The hand is the same hand. The hand has learned that it has been used.

I will learn to draw a circle by other means.

I try once more, this time to please myself, to remember the face of the woman who taught me what a circle was, a young Tuscan farmwife who lifted me at the age of three and said *guarda, Leonardo, la luna è il cerchio del cielo*. The sun was on the back of her neck. The smile was for the two of us. The smile lived only between her and me, and now it lives in no one, because the face is gone.

I have known the face was gone for some years now. I keep trying to find it. I keep finding the shape where the face was, the way one finds the chair when the lamp is out and there is no lamp.

I set the compass down.

SALAI IS AT THE WINDOW.

He stands in the morning light with his face turned toward where I am, which is not the same as looking at me. His eyes have, in the last six months, begun to whiten in the way old men's eyes whiten when the body has finished with light. He has been at the window since first prayer. He can feel the heat of the young spring sun even when he cannot quite see what is in it.

He paints, when he paints, from a low stool with his face perhaps a hand's-breadth from the panel. He paints what he can paint: drapery, backgrounds, architecture. I paint the faces. We have made it work. We have made many things work that no one looking from outside the room would think could be made to work.

The blue, he says, has not come back. The grey has only deepened. The

yellow has begun to dim. He does not complain. He has never complained. He whistles, sometimes, the small Milanese tune his mother sang at Oreno; he whistles it in this Florentine room two hundred miles from her, and he whistles it for me, who has forgotten my own.

Florence in April smells of wet stone and new green and the morning smoke of the laundresses' fires in the alleys behind the Annunziata.

A boy at our door.

He has a letter.

THE LETTER IS FROM A MERCHANT.

The wax is sealed with a small bird, a song-thrush, I think, the *tordo*, which means nothing to me and would mean something to a Florentine who knew the family. I do not know the family. I break the seal. The handwriting is good Florentine merchant's hand, schooled but not professional, written by a man who can write his own letters and prefers to.

Maestro Leonardo,

I write to beg your assistance in a matter most unusual. My wife Lisa is afflicted by a thing no physician will name. I would set the whole truth on this page, Maestro, but if I wrote it plainly no sane man would come, and I find that I need a man who will come. The physicians bring tinctures. She drinks them. She smiles to thank them. She does not improve. She smiles, Maestro. She has smiled at every physician who has crossed my threshold. The smile is on her face when I leave the house and the smile is on her face when I return. She smiles in her sleep. She smiles as I write this, in the room across from this one, where she sits up against her pillows and looks at the wall.

The smile is not her smile.

I would not write to a maestro of your reputation for so small a thing as a wife's illness, if I had not heard, from a friend, that you have closed doors of the kind that are not doors. The friend would not say more. He said you would understand the phrase. He said to write to you. He said you would not laugh at the letter.

I do not laugh, Maestro. I do not know how to laugh at this. My wife is sitting in the next room smiling, and the smile is not hers.

Come to my house. See her. Tell me if there is anything that can be done.

Your humble servant, Francesco del Giocondo.

I fold the letter. I do not laugh at the letter. I set it on the table beside the compass that has failed four times today to draw a circle.

The friend who told the merchant about closing doors of the kind that are not doors did not get the phrase from me. I have spoken it to no one. The friend got it from someone with a keeper's knowledge. Someone outside my family knows my name now. They will keep knowing. The work has been a small private thing in my family for as long as I can trace; the work is no longer small or private. Someone has spoken.

"Salaino."

"Maestro."

"A summons."

"From where."

"From here. Florence."

"From whom."

"A merchant. His wife."

He turns from the window.

"Sick."

"Yes."

"The kind we know about."

"Yes."

"The smile."

"The smile."

He has heard it in my voice before I have read him the line. He has known the line for years now, since the morning we left Milan with the box and the wrapped panel and three changes of linen. He has been waiting, perhaps, for a line like this one.

"Then we go," he says. "Of course we go."

"There is one thing first."

“What.”

“The chest.”

“Ah.”

I OPEN THE WOODEN CHEST WHERE I KEEP CORRESPONDENCE I DO NOT THROW away. I lift the wrapped panel from beneath the topmost layer. The wrapping is the same linen Antonio used. The cord is the same country knot. I have not unwrapped this panel since the morning after the refectory.

I unwrap it now.

Her portrait. The face at peace. The eyes closed. The mouth in the small smile of a critic who had been outflanked and had chosen, for dignity, to call the outflanking a draw. The gold frame holds. Four lines of gold along the four edges. The frame is still bright.

I look at the mouth.

In the corner where the upper and lower lips meet on the right side, the gold has cracked. The crack is small. A hairline. Not even the full corner. Just at the edge.

In the cracked place, the mouth has changed.

The small smile of a critic at peace is no longer a small smile of a critic at peace. There is a new expression beginning to form in the corner of the lips, in the place where the gold has thinned. The expression has not yet arrived. The expression is the way an outline almost becomes a face.

I have seen this outline before. In the shadow on the workshop wall above the wrapped panel. In the corner pigment of the refectory after the ritual.

I have not made this expression. I painted her at peace. The peace is mostly intact. The peace has begun, in one corner, to loosen.

Salai has felt me go still.

“What.”

“She is moving.”

He waits to see if I will say more. I do not. He turns back to the window.

I REWRAP THE PANEL. I RETIE THE CORD, KNOTTED IN THE COUNTRY KNOT. I place the panel back in the chest.

I cross to the larger chest, the one I brought from Milan. I open it. My grandfather's box is inside, where I have not opened it since the morning after the refectory.

I lift the lid.

Three working vials remain, re-waxed by my own hand: blue, red, gold. The four others are still unbroken, still emergency. The journal lies at the bottom in its oil-stained leather. The pots' temperatures have not changed.

The gold is still cold.

I close the box. I lift it from the larger chest. I place it on the table beside the merchant's letter. The box is heavy for its size, the same wrong weight it had on the road from Vinci. The weight has not lessened in all the years since. I had thought, perhaps, that the weight was something the box had borrowed. The weight is something the box owns.

Salai has come away from the window. He cannot see the box on the table; he can hear it.

"When do we leave?"

"Tomorrow."

Tomorrow does not come.

What comes, an hour past dark, is a fist on the street door, and boots on my stair, and a rider in the colours of Cesare Borgia with the road still steaming off him. He does not sit. He does not take wine. He recites, the way men recite who have been made to say a thing back to their master before being trusted to carry it: the Duke Valentino requires his engineer. The fortresses of the Romagna will not survey themselves. I am to come at once, with my instruments. The word requires belongs to a man who owns other words and does not use them.

I am fifty years old this month. I have a wall in Milan that is already beginning to shed its paint, a bound thing in a chest that has started, in one cracked corner, to smile, and now a letter on my table from a merchant whose wife smiles and does not stop. And I am to spend my spring drawing the killing angles of other men's walls, because a keeper who ends on a prince's gallows

keeps nothing.

Salai does not ask. He hears the boots go down the stair and begins, without a word, to pack the instruments.

I take the merchant's letter from the table. I read it once more, the smile that is not her smile, the friend who knows what no friend should know. Someone baits this hook, and casts it into my one clear pool, and waits. When I come to Florence, and I will come, it will be to take the hook in my hand and follow the line back to the man who tied it.

I lift the lid of my grandfather's box. I lay the letter on top of the journal, where the important unanswered things are kept.

Forgive me, Ser Francesco. Forgive me, Madonna Lisa, whoever is wearing you.

The work is never over. The work is only postponed, and postponement is a debt, and the debt is always collected.

I close the box.

THE PIGMENTS WERE ONLY THE BEGINNING AN
EXCLUSIVE PREVIEW OF BOOK ONE: THE MONA
LISA CAGE

*Some faces refuse to be painted because they are not faces at all. They are doors
wearing the shape of features.*

Antonio da Vinci, sealed journals

Leonardo da Vinci
Milan, Santa Maria delle Grazie
February 1497

The face of Judas Iscariot has defeated me for the seventeenth time.

I stand in the refectory of Santa Maria delle Grazie with my brush a hand's breadth from the wall, and I watch the empty place where the betrayer must sit. The afternoon light falls through the high windows at an angle I measured to the degree three years ago and have not needed to measure since. It lays my half-finished apostles in their proper shadow. It finds, without fail, the one patch of plaster I cannot fill.

I prepared that patch myself this morning. Slaked lime and the fine grey ash they dig at Pozzuoli, worked to the smoothness of skin. Other men race wet plaster and let the wall dictate their hours. I will not be hurried by a wall. I have devised my own ground, my own slow oils, a method I am certain will outlast the fashion of fresco and hold my colours true long after I am dust. I am certain of it the way I am certain of arithmetic. That certainty is the first thing in this room that will betray me, though I do not know it yet.

The surface is perfect. Smooth. Ready.

And it is watching me.

Madness. Six nights without proper sleep, and now I credit a wall with intentions.

I bring my hand forward. The bristle touches plaster, and I draw it down in what should be the curve of a cheekbone, the simplest stroke a child could manage, a line I have set down ten thousand times. The pigment goes wrong under my hand. Not the weight I ground into it, not the ochre I warmed with a breath of vermilion. The stroke bends where I will it straight. It thickens where I bear down light. It leaves on the wall a mark that belongs to no face I have ever studied, and I have opened the skin of the dead to learn how a face is hung upon its bone.

I step back. At the edge of my sight the mark slides, the way a fish turns under the surface of a pond. I look at it square and it is only a smear of earth and oil, still and stupid and mine. I look away, and it moves.

There. Again.

A rational man would name it the failing of a tired eye. I am a rational man. I have spent my life chasing the causes that other men hand to God or the Devil because the labour of looking is too much for them. I have cut muscle from bone by candle to see how the arm is rigged. I have watched the kite ride the wind to learn how weight makes peace with air. I have observed and measured and set down what I found, brick upon brick, until I built myself a house of reasons I believed would shelter me from anything.

And I cannot tell you what the blank space is doing.

My hand shakes. The brush jumps. A spray of ochre crosses the fresh plaster, and for the space of one heartbeat the spatter holds a shape, a wide and grinning mouth, before I drag my rag across it and it is gone.

The wall takes the correction without complaint. It returns to its smooth waiting, to that patient emptiness that has thrown down every figure I have raised against it.

Seventeen tries. The first was only poor work. I had meant a Judas of shadow and guilt, the treachery plain in the set of the brow, and what dried on the wall

overnight was not the man I painted but something arranged where he had been, less a face than a hole worn into the shape of one. I scraped it back. The next was worse, and the next worse than that, each ruin further from any human grammar, until the morning my hand moved without me.

I do not remember painting the third. I remember the grey light. I remember loading the brush with burnt sienna and lead white. Then a torn place in the day, a page gone from the book, and awareness returning with my breakfast climbing my throat and a thing on the plaster no living hand should have been able to lay there. I would not look at it straight. I took it only at the edge of my eye as I scrubbed it away, and even so it has not left me: a face that was also a doorway, an eye that was also a mouth, teeth crowded where no jaw could hold them.

The prior found me an hour after, on my knees, washing sick from the refectory stones with my own sleeve.

That was months ago. Nothing since has improved my Judas.

A tread on the stones behind me now, soft, deliberate, and the small dry click of beads. I do not turn. I know the rhythm of those sandals the way a condemned man knows the bell that counts his mornings.

“The Duke grows impatient, Maestro.” Prior Bandello comes to my shoulder and folds his hands, the rosary moving through his fingers one bead at a time. He is a small man with mild eyes and a stillness that costs him effort, and I have learned to mistrust the courtesy in him precisely because it never slips. “Three years. Three years of paint and scaffolding, and a wall that is twelve parts finished and one part empty. The brothers have begun to take their meals looking at the empty part.”

“Masterworks are not hurried.”

“Masterworks are not abandoned in the middle, either.” Another bead. The click of it is very loud in the long room. “Ludovico asks after you. Daily, now. He has begun to use a word I do not enjoy carrying across the city to you.” He pauses, to be sure I will ask, and when I do not, he gives it to me anyway. “Unwell. He fears you are unwell.”

The word settles between us and does not lift.

In another man’s mouth it would mean a fever, a week abed, a physician with

his jars of leeches. In Ludovico Sforza's court it has a wider reach. It can mean a weakness that wants correcting. It can mean a madness that wants a locked room and a strong door. A duke who has paid three years of a painter's keep and has a bare wall to show his guests will eventually decide which meaning suits his purse.

"I am perfectly well," I tell him. "I labour at a problem of method. Nothing more."

"What problem of method consumes three years?"

The kind that watches from the gaps in a man's work. The kind that paints itself while I sleep on my feet. The kind that has begun to follow me home, that waits in the black of a basin when I try to wash the turpentine from my hands and looks up at me out of the water.

"The face of Judas," I say. "I cannot find the living man who carries the particular quality I need. I have searched for him in every quarter of Milan."

That much is not a lie. I have hunted that face through the prisons and the dockside taverns and the fine rooms where worse men than dock thieves take their wine. The merchant who sold his own brother to the debt-collectors. The courtier whose whispers emptied a rival's house. The priest with the wife of a wool-trader warming his bed. Each of them sat for me. Each of them gave me a study in greed or cowardice or appetite, and not one of them gave me what I found in my seventeenth ruin.

Not one of them was hungry in the way the wall is hungry.

"I shall pray you find him soon." Bandello inclines his head, and the beads go still in his hand, and for a moment the mildness in him thins to something that has measured me and is keeping the sum to itself. "Before the Duke finds his own use for the word."

He withdraws. His sandals carry the sound of him down the length of the refectory and out, and I am left with my eleven apostles in their failing light and the empty place that no longer feels like an absence. An absence is a nothing. This has begun to feel like a held breath.

That was four hours past. I have not moved.

The light has gone from gold to amber to the deep bruised violet that comes

before the dark. The shadows have stretched from the windows and reached across the floor like fingers feeling toward the wall. At the centre of my composition the Christ keeps his arms open in the gesture I built the whole table to carry. Peter still grips his small bright knife. John still sways toward sleep. Thomas still lifts the one raised finger of his doubt.

And Judas is still nothing. A void with an edge to it. A man-shaped wound in my three years' work.

Go. The brothers will want the room for vespers. Gather your brushes and your pots and go home and come back at dawn with a rested eye and a steadier hand.

I do not go. I cannot take my eyes from the empty place, and not because I wish to look at it. Because I have become afraid of what it may do the moment I stop.

The smell comes first.

It comes from nowhere, out of no jar I have opened and no corner I can name. Paint and plaster and the clean nutty oil of linseed, the honest furniture of my craft. Then, beneath that, the other thing. Meat kept too long in summer. Cut flowers left to soften in their own water. A sweetness laid over rot to hide it, and failing, and somehow worse for the failing.

I know the smell of death. I have spent whole nights with the opened dead, reading the architecture under the skin by a guttering wick while the stink watered my eyes. That smell was honest. It was only flesh going back to the earth that lent it, the plain arithmetic of decay.

This smell is not honest. This smell intends something.

Leave. Leave now. Whatever moves in this room, you will not meet it alone and in the dark.

The counsel is good. My feet will not take it. I stand rooted on the cold stone, my eyes fixed where Judas is not, and I watch my painting begin to change.

The faces of the apostles are moving.

Peter's honest fury loosens at its edges, the features running like colour caught in rain. The grief in John slides toward something less clean, a sweetness

gone sly. And Thomas, my doubting Thomas, his one raised finger curls slowly inward, past questioning, into a hook, into a thing made not to ask but to take hold.

The empty place grows wider.

Not larger. Wider. As a mouth widens. As if the wall has begun to gape, to draw in the long table and the open-armed Christ and every figure I have raised in three years of labour, and as if all that labour were never a supper at all but only the long careful laying of a meal.

I stumble back. My heel finds a loose stone and I go down hard, my palms skidding on grit and the dust of centuries, the breath knocked white out of me. On the table the candles I keep for the close work gutter and leap, and the shadows of the apostles lurch up the walls and do not move as the flames move, do not move as shadows are bound by every law I have ever proven to move.

And in the empty place, something pushes through.

Not the sly ripple I might have laid at the door of a tired eye. This has form. This has weight. A shape pressing against the inner face of my painting from the far side, the way a hand presses into wet cloth and the cloth takes the print of every finger, the way a drowned face rises pale under still water before it breaks the surface. Something vast leaning its whole patience against a door that was never built to open.

Run.

I am on my feet without the memory of rising. I do not gather my brushes. I do not stop the pots or pinch the wicks. I do not look back to learn what wears the wall now.

I run.

The refectory door bangs wide before me and the night air takes my face like a hand laid in blessing, cold and clean and empty of that rot-sweet wrongness. I cross the cloister with my heart slamming, past the chapel where the brothers are gathering their voices for vespers, out through the gate and into the street, and Milan closes over me like water over a dropped stone. Hawkers crying the last of their wares before the dark. Servants bent under the day's marketing. A dog at a bone, a child at a grievance, the whole loud ordinary commerce of the living,

none of it knowing that something has begun to wake behind the wall of Santa Maria delle Grazie.

I do not stop until the Corte Vecchia.

My workshop holds three rooms on the upper floor of a house that has outlived its best years. The stairs complain under me, each in its own register, a music I usually find friendly and tonight hear as warning. The door sticks in its frame as it always sticks in the wet months, and I shoulder it, and it gives, and the familiar world receives me. Warmth. The amber of candles in their sconces. The smell of turpentine over everything like a benediction. Sketches pinned to every surface that will take a pin. Clay studies furred with dust on shelves I built too high to dust. Drawings of engines spread across the long table like the plans for a siege. In the corner the portrait of a councillor's wife who paid her deposit before the autumn and will go to her grave without her likeness, because I have not been able to look at a blank panel these three years without the panel looking back.

And at the centre of the long table, between the diagram of a flooded moat and the little bronze model of a horse that will never be cast, the box sits where it has sat for two days, and where I go on pretending, for two days now, that I do not feel it watching the room.

Old wood, dark with the oil of long handling. A lid sealed with red wax, broken now, resealed by my own clumsy thumb. And pressed into the older wax, sharp after thirty years, a mark I know before my mind consents to know it.

A brush crossed with a quill. Seven stars set in a ring.

My grandfather's seal.

It comes to me the long way, as everything true comes. A letter from my father begins it, Ser Piero, notary of Florence, a man who has not written to me in six years and who writes now in the small deliberate hand of a man who charges by the legal phrase: the chest your grandfather left in my keeping has altered, there is frost on the wax in a warm room, come and take this thing out of my house. So I go. Four days on winter roads to Vinci, and I stand in the February rain over a grave whose stone has gone soft-edged with thirty years of weather. Antonio da Vinci has lain in that churchyard since I was a boy of

twelve. I held the cord they lowered him by, the autumn the leaves came down the colour of old coins, and I understand only now that the family was burying more than a man. My father will not hand the box over under his own roof. He gives it to me on the road outside the town, wrapped and corded, and says only that it goes to me and to no one else, and that I am not to write to him of it again. Four days back. The cart is in the stable. The driver is paid.

And for two days I circle this table the way a dog circles a snake it has already been bitten by.

We open it the first evening, Salai and I, by lamplight, layer by layer, saying very little. Seven sealed pots of pigment, each stopped with wax and marked in my grandfather's hand: three set apart for use, their seals scored with a single line, and four bound over in lead, which the journal names emergency and instructs me, twice, in a script pressed hard enough to furrow the page, never to open while another road remains. Beneath the pots, the journal itself, small, leather-bound, oil-stained at the corners, with a loose page folded on top and addressed to me. Beneath everything, wrapped in linen and tied with the country knot he taught me at six, a panel the size of my two palms.

I do not read the loose page aloud, not that evening. Salai watches me fold it away and has the grace, or the cunning, not to ask.

Tonight he is out in the rain, at whatever it is he does in the rain, and I am alone with the box, and I take the page out again, because a man returns to a wound to learn whether it is healing.

Leonardo,

If this is in your hands, the signs have come, and you have lived through their coming. That is more than I dared promise myself.

I have little time and less ink for it. The thing I spent my life containing is patient past any human measure, and it waits for men like us. It feels every stroke we set down, the way a spider feels a thread go taut. You have the gift. I saw it in you at seven, in your hungry eyes. That hunger is what makes us dangerous to it, and it dangerous to you.

The pots hold pigments mixed by a method older than Rome. They will seal what nothing else will touch. Three you may spend. Four you must not, save at

the last need of all. They exact a price, and the price is never the one you brace for.

The journal is the shadow of what I knew. The body of it is in Vinci, in my workshop, what the fire spared. I burned more than I should have. I was afraid of what a book can do in the wrong hands, and at the end I could no longer tell whether yours would be the right ones. Forgive me that. You will have to find the rest the way I found it.

There is more I should tell you and cannot, not on a page. When you have read this, unwrap the panel. Speak to the portrait. Make her tell you what I am no longer here to say. She will not want to. Compel her.

I am sorry the burden falls to you. I could not break the thing, only hold it, and a held thing is only ever borrowed time.

Close the doors, grandson.

With a love the grave does not lessen,

Antonio

Two days I obey every line of that letter but the one it took the most courage to write.

I lift the wrapped panel from the bottom of the box. The linen is cold. The cord is knotted in the country knot, the kind that does not slip even when the carried thing is carried by a child too small to be careful. I untie it the way he taught me, and the linen falls away, and I turn the panel over.

A portrait no bigger than my palm. A woman I have never seen.

The letter slips from my fingers. I watch it settle to the stone, his words coming to rest like leaves on the skin of a still pond.

Speak to the portrait.

I look at the small painting in my hands. The woman regards me from her frame, her eyes catching the candlelight and keeping it. Her features are pleasant and forgettable, a face that would empty from memory the moment it left a room. Brown hair under a plain veil. Pale skin. A mouth set in an expression that lives between a smile and something the smile is drawn over.

She looks hungry.

Foolishness. She is earth and oil on a board. She cannot look like anything.

Even as I frame the denial, the eyes in the portrait move. A small thing, a sliding I might lay at the door of the candle's wavering or my own worn sight. The painted pupils track left. Then right. Then they settle on me, and hold, with an attention that lifts the hair along my arms.

"You took your time," the portrait says.

I am against the workbench before I know I have moved. My hip strikes the edge and the pain of it flares up through my side, sharp and honest, the only honest thing in the room.

"I have waited a long while." The lips of the painted woman do not stir. The voice rises out of the board itself, out of the wood and the colour and the varnish, as though the materials have between them learned the trick of speech. "He set me here before you were a man grown. He said you would come to it in your own time. He said the signs would show and the box would be carried and you would stand before me wearing the very face he wore the first night I spoke to him. He was right in every particular. He usually was."

I am asleep. I dropped at last in the refectory, six nights unrested, and now I dream of speaking boards.

"You are not asleep." Something close to amusement moves under the voice. "Though I grant you the comfort of the thought. It is easier to credit a dream than a door. Easier to wave off an impossible voice than to admit the world is wider and stranger than the house of reasons you have built to live in."

I make myself look at her as I would look at any panel set before me for appraisal. Not at the thing she claims to be. At the work. The hand that laid her down. This is the discipline of my whole life and the only wall I have left to put at my back.

The painting is no masterwork. The drawing is sound and the modelling careful, the work of a competent journeyman who would never trouble the great names, the kind of likeness that hangs in a merchant's hall to prove he once had money. The woman is rendered with skill and no fire.

And yet the thing disturbs me past my power to say why. The proportions are wrong, but wrong along directions I cannot lay a rule against. The space inside the frame shifts when I shift, the painted eyes coming with me past every trick I

know for fixing a gaze upon a viewer. At the edge of sight the brushwork crawls, the strokes rearranging into figures that form and break apart like a thought I almost have and lose.

“What are you?”

“I am what waits on the far side. Or a piece of it. A splinter driven off the whole.” The voice does not hurry. “Your grandfather took me thirty years ago, when I came too near a door he was painting. He bound me into this board by a method I had not met before and have not met since. I would dearly like to know how he did it. He would never say.”

“What do you want?”

“What every hunger wants. To take in. To grow by it. To become larger than I was.” A pause that has weight. “But he bound me well. I cannot reach for anything without the leave of the hand that bound me, and that hand is thirty years in the ground, so its refusal has become a thing without end. You may imagine how that sits with me.”

“Then why answer me at all?”

“Because he made me.” For the first time something like temper threads the voice, dark and dry. “It is written into the binding. When the one who holds this board compels me, I must answer, and answer true. I find it a tiresome leash. I will give you the words and not one grain more than the words require, so put your questions well. A poorly asked question earns a true answer that helps you not at all.”

I lift the portrait from its linen. The frame is cold against my palms, colder than wood has any right to be on a night with a fire on the hearth, a cold that climbs my wrists and sets my teeth on edge. The painted eyes follow me as I turn her to the light and back.

“You say a splinter. A splinter of what?”

“Of the hunger behind the doors. The appetite that lives in the gap between the thing painted and the thing itself.” A silence, and under it the suggestion of vastness, the way a single dropped stone tells you the depth of a well. “We have no name your mouth could shape. We have no form your mind could hold and stay whole. Leave the names to your grandfather’s books. They will frighten you

better than I can.”

“And the door he painted. You came at that.”

“He was good, the old man. Better than most who ever lifted a brush. When he painted, he painted true, and truth is the danger. Truth thins the wall. Truth wears the seam.” The voice changes, and what enters it is worse than menace, because it is admiration. “You are better than he was. I can taste it on the air of this room. I can see how the light leans toward your hands when you reach for a brush. There has not been a danger like you in a very long age. You are the most dangerous man alive, and you have spent three years widening a door with your own skill and calling it a failure to finish a face.”

The cold reaches into my chest and sits there. It is not fear, or not only fear. It is nearer to recognition, and that is the part I cannot bear.

“The empty place in the refectory,” I say. “Where Judas will not come. That is a door.”

“You have been painting one for three years and grieving that you could not. Every stroke you set there opens it a finger wider. Every Judas you raise and scrape away wears the seam thinner. It is nearly wide enough now. You felt it tonight. You felt the first of it lean through.”

“I felt something press against the wall.”

“A tendril. One blind finger put through to test the air.” The painted mouth does not move and still I know it has changed. “When the door stands open, what comes will not be a finger.”

The candles drop low all at once, as if a breath had crossed the room, and in the failing light I see them at the edges of things. Shapes that are not furniture. Faces that hold their lines only so long as I do not turn to them. Mouths opening on a black with no floor to it. Then the wicks recover, the flames stand up gold and ordinary, and I am alone with a board and a dead man’s letter on the floor.

“How is it closed?” My voice holds steady. I take some small foolish pride in that. “The door. How do I seal it before the rest comes through?”

“The pigments. He spent the back half of his life perfecting them. They bind. They seal. They shut a door that common paint slides off.”

I look at the three pots he marked for use. The wax on them is broken since

the first evening, enough to see and no more. The first holds a colour that turns between red and gold and, at a certain tilt, the dark of dried blood. The second is blue gone to black gone to silver, the blue of deep water or of the last sky before dawn. The third gives off a light of its own, white and silver and gold together, like the moon run to liquid and poured into glass.

“How are they used?”

“That I cannot tell you.”

“You said you must answer true.”

“I must answer true. I cannot answer what was never given to me. He bound me with these colours. He never taught me the binding. I have felt what they do from the wrong side of it, which has taught me to fear them and nothing more.”

Wonderful. A magic with no instruction and a teacher who was

“There are notes.” The voice cuts across the thought as though it hears it, and perhaps it does. “The book he sent you is the shadow. He tells you so himself, on his page. The body of it is in Vinci, in his workshop, what he learned of the shutting of doors, the part the fire spared.” A pause, and the pleasure in it is unmistakable. “Three days’ hard riding, I believe. Such a long way, and the wall thinning by the hour. I do wonder which will arrive first. You at the notes, or the thing at you.”

“You would have me ride three days and leave the door to widen behind me.”

“I would have you do nothing. I am past wanting, remember. I merely observe that you have two roads and no good one. Ride, and pray the door is patient. Stay, and face it with colours you do not know how to spend and the shadow of a book whose body was half given to the fire.” The painted mouth does not move, and still I feel it smile. “I confess I am curious to see which you choose. It has been a long time since anything was curious to me.”

The workshop door bursts open.

I spin with the vial raised like a blade, my body falling of its own accord into a guard I did not know my muscles remembered. The figure in the doorway freezes with one hand on the frame, dark eyes gone wide.

Salai.

He is soaked. The rain runs from his hair down the sharp young planes of his face and off his jaw, and his thin shirt clings to him, and his boots leave dark prints on boards I swept three days past and will sweep again tomorrow. He squints into the room, into the candlelight, and rubs at one eye with the heel of his hand as though the brightness troubles him, though my candles are low and the room is more shadow than light.

“You’re home.” The innocence in his voice is a coat thrown over something he would rather I did not see. “I didn’t look for you so early.”

“It is near midnight.”

“Is it.” He makes a show of consulting the black windows, as if the dark out there might have lied to him. “The hours got away from me.”

Seventeen years old, and seven of them under my roof, since the morning his father brought him to me at ten with the broken hope that I might make of him something other than a thief. I have failed at that as completely as a man can fail. Salai steals what is not nailed down and a fair portion of what is. He lies with the ease of a poet and the open face of a saint. He has cost me more in replaced silver and quieted constables than most men spend on a household entire.

He is also the one soul in Milan I trust without floor or limit.

“What’s that?” He is already crossing the room, already reaching, the old thieving instinct running ahead of his sense, his eyes on the vial in my hand. He puts his face close to it and frowns, and tilts it, and frowns harder, and I see him misjudge the distance and pull his fingers back a hair too late, brushing the cold glass he had meant to pinch clean.

“Do not touch it.”

Something in the way I say it stops him, not the words, which he would shrug off, but whatever rides beneath them. The fear I cannot wholly keep down.

The careless mischief drains out of his face. What it leaves is the thing under the boy, the quick hard intelligence, the loyalty with teeth, the readiness for violence I have seen him show exactly once, in an alley by the docks, over a man who had put a knife toward me.

“What’s happened?” He comes closer, close enough that I smell the wine and the cheap rosewater of whatever company he kept tonight. “You’ve the look of a

man who's seen the dead walk."

I have. I am seeing it still. The board behind you wears a woman's face that moves when I look away, and somewhere across this city a door is widening that will let in a thing worse than any devil the Church has put a name to.

"Sit," I tell him. "I have a thing to tell you, and you are going to have to believe it."

He sits. He listens. And when I have laid it all out, the empty place and the running faces and the box with the dead man's seal and the board that answers when it is asked, he does the one thing I did not expect.

He takes up the portrait and looks at it.

"She's not moving now," he says. "She's only a painting. A poor one, if you want the truth, no offence to your grandfather." He brings it nearer his face and squints again, and turns it toward the candle to find the light, the way a man does when the light has begun, lately, to fail him. "Plain little thing."

"She moved before. She spoke."

"I believe you." He says it too quickly, and then is quiet a moment, and I watch the belief cost him. He has spent seven years arranging the world into things that can be picked up, sold, outrun, or talked past, and I have just handed him one that fits no pocket and answers no lie. His throat works. When he speaks again the bravado has thinned to something nearer the truth. "I have seen what you can do with a brush, Maestro. If you tell me a painting spoke to you, then a painting spoke. God help us both." He sets her down, face to the ceiling, and meets my eyes, and there is no laughter left in his. "What do we do?"

"We?"

"You think I'll stand by and let you walk into this alone?" His jaw sets. The rain has flattened his hair to his brow and made him young again, near the boy who first came through my door with defiance in his look and another man's purse already in his sleeve. "Seven years, Maestro. Seven years of your ruin and your genius and your mad impossible schemes. You think I leave now, when at last it gets interesting?"

"This is not interesting. This is deadly."

"With you those have never been two different things." He rises, the water

still running off him, and goes to the window. Below, Milan lies under the rain, a city of small troubles and small mercies, with no notion of what has woken three streets and a churchyard away. "What did she tell you. About the shutting of the door."

"That I must use the colours my grandfather left. But she cannot tell me how."

"Then we find out how." He turns back, and his dark eyes hold the stubbornness that has kept him at my side through every scandal and every triumph and the long grey stretches between. "We go tonight. We take the colours. We try."

"We may die. We may come to something a great deal worse than dying."

"We may also win." The grin breaks across him sudden and sharp, the look of a man who has staked his neck on longer odds and walked away counting his winnings. "When have you ever turned your back on a thing because you did not understand it? When have you refused to put your hand in the fire to see how the fire is made?"

Never. The answer is never, and we both know it. From the opened dead to the engines I draw that no foundry will pour, I have gone wherever the question led, and never once asked the price at the door.

But this is not natural philosophy. This is not the pushing back of ignorance one hard-won span at a time. This is the thing my grandfather gave his life to, and could not kill, and in the end could only cage.

And yet.

The door is opening. Whether I face it tonight, or run for Vinci, or bar myself in this workshop until the thing leans through and finds me anyway, the door is opening, and my hand opened it. My gift widened it. The skill that is the truest thing about me has been, these three years, a key turning slowly in a lock I never saw.

If any man can shut it, I can.

If any man must, then it is I.

"Very well." I set the vial down among its fellows. "We go tonight. But you stay at my back. You do nothing I have not told you to do. And if it takes me, if I

fall, or fail, or stand up wearing something that is no longer Leonardo, you will not try to save me. You will run, and you will not stop until Vinci, and you will find what survives of his notes, and you will learn to fight this without me.”

“I’m not going to stand there and watch you.”

“Promise me.” I turn full on him, and whatever he reads in my face cuts the rest off in his throat. “Promise me, Salai. Or I go alone and bar the door behind me.”

The silence draws out. The rain drums the glass. Somewhere off in the dark a dog gives tongue at shadows only it can see.

“I promise,” he says at last, and the words come out of him the way a tooth comes out of the jaw.

He is lying.

I know he is lying. Salai has never in his life kept a promise that stood in the way of a thing he wanted, and what he wants is to not lose me. The lie comforts me past all reason. It tells me I am not so alone as I have spent my life believing.

Dangerous. Love is the most dangerous of all the colours. It opens a seam in a man that any enemy with eyes can find.

But I cannot send him from me. I have tried, across the years, to push him toward some safer life, one with no speaking boards in it and no inheritance of dread. He will not go. He never goes.

Some doors will not close.

“Then come,” I say. “Before I remember how to be a sensible man.”

We leave the portrait where she lies. I will not carry a bound hunger toward a door that is already opening, however much she knows. Whatever waits in the refectory may be her kin, and I have read enough of my grandfather’s letter to guess what two such things might say to one another if I were fool enough to bring them within a wall’s breadth. She does not protest. She only watches us out of those painted eyes that see further than paint was ever meant to see. The letter I fold small and slide into my doublet, against the breast, over the heart. The three pots I wrap and settle in a leather pouch and hang at my belt, where I can feel their cold through the leather and through my clothes and, I half believe, through the skin beneath.

The rain has stopped. The streets still run with it, the puddles holding the broken light of the few torches that burn outside a tavern door or a rich man's gate. Milan at midnight is no friend to a walker. Thieves work the alleys. The watch patrols the wide ways with a keener interest in a bribe than in any citizen's throat. There is danger in every black mouth of every close.

None of it touches me tonight. I have seen what waits in the empty place. After that, a cutpurse with a knife is a thing to walk past.

We move through the city without speaking. Salai knows these streets in his blood, which alley turns blind and which gives onto a yard, which corner hides a man and which roof carries him to the next street if the running starts. He leads me by ways I would never find. Past the shuttered stalls of the Mercato, where the day's fish has left its ghost on the cold air. Under an arch where a beggar sleeps sitting up, his breath rattling, and does not wake for us. Along a canal where the water lies black and unmoving and throws back the one lit window above it, doubled, wrong, so that for a moment I cannot tell which window is the true one and which the water's lie, and I look away before the old fear can name what else still water has begun to show me.

Twice on the way I see him put a hand to a wall to steady a step the old Salai would have taken sure-footed in full dark. Once he checks at a low step I had thought plain to any eye, his boot finding the edge a beat late, his weight catching wrong, and he curses under his breath and rubs at his eyes with the back of his wrist and walks on. I say nothing. He would not thank me for the noticing. But the cold at my belt seems to deepen, and I think of my grandfather's hand pressed against mine, and the patterns the tremor drew, and I begin to understand that the price the colours exact may not always be drawn from the man who spends them.

The monastery sleeps. The brothers have sung their vespers and gone to their cells to dream whatever is left a man to dream after a life given over. One light burns in the whole grey pile of it, a candle in the prior's window, where Bandello no doubt prays for the finishing of the wall that has plagued his refectory three years.

I made my own key to the garden door, years past, when I needed my

painting at hours the Church frowns upon. I have used it more times than I could count, slipping in and out like a draught, working by candle while Milan believed Leonardo asleep in his bed.

The lock turns now with its old soft click, and the door gives onto the garden.

The smell takes me at the threshold.

The same smell as the afternoon, stronger now. Paint and plaster and linseed, and under it the rot that wears sweetness like a mask. I do not need to name it twice. We both know what it is.

“Do you smell that,” Salai breathes.

“Yes.”

“What is it.”

“The door. Opening.”

We cross the garden without a word between us. Rosemary and thyme drag at our legs and give up their sharp green scent into the dark, a mercy of one breath before the wrongness closes over it again. The refectory door stands ahead of us, dark wood in darker stone, a door like any door but for the thing that waits behind it.

I reach for the handle.

Salai’s hand shuts on my arm. The grip is hard, harder than I look for in a man who has spent his life dodging honest work. His face is bloodless in the thin starlight, and his eyes are wide, and in them is a thing I have not once seen in seven years.

Fear.

“Leonardo.” It is barely a breath. “There’s something on the wall.”

I look past him, through the small grille set into the door, into the black of the refectory beyond.

The empty place where Judas will not come is no longer empty.

Something has painted itself there in the hours I was gone. Something that looks back at me through the iron grille with eyes that hold their own pale light, with a smile drawn too wide for any jaw, with features I last saw an hour ago on a board no bigger than my palm in my own workshop across the sleeping city.

The same face. The bound thing's face. The splinter my grandfather drove into a frame and chained with a method he carried to his grave.

She has a sister.

And the sister was never bound at all.

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

SOME DOORS ARE NEVER FINISHED CLOSING.

Tradition holds that Leonardo lingered a long while over the face of Judas as he worked on *The Last Supper*, and that his prior, the real Vincenzo Bandello, grew impatient waiting for it to be finished. The wall painting really did begin to deteriorate within a few decades, because Leonardo worked in oil and tempera on dry plaster rather than in true fresco. That experiment is part of why the masterpiece was fragile almost from the day it was done.

Antonio da Vinci was a real man, Leonardo's grandfather. His role here as a keeper, and the dates this story lends him, belong to the fiction. The keeper-lineage, the pigments, and La Famelica are mine.

Some of the work that survives in our museums, this story supposes, was not entirely the artist's choice.

Leo Di Lux

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Leo Di Lux writes supernatural thrillers about the dark history hidden behind famous paintings. The Painted Souls series began with a question no art historian could answer: why did Leonardo carry the Mona Lisa with him for the rest of his life and never deliver it to the man who commissioned it?

The answer, it turns out, was worse than anyone imagined.

When not writing, Leo can be found in museums standing too close to Renaissance portraits, watching the eyes.

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Where Hollywood's dreams become nightmares.

Book 2 · Phantom Cut

Hollywood wants final cut. Something else disagrees.

Book 3 · Shadow Reel

A celluloid labyrinth stitched from living shadows.

Book 4 · Final Projection

When the credits roll on reality, which ending survives?

Thank you for reading! One quick review keeps the reel turning.

Read it slow. Read it at night. Trust nothing in the corners.

Leo